

CITY: PG 3

Delhi Metro Phase V(B): 97 km, 65 new stations



NATION: PG 5

Assam polls: Counting to decide BJP hat-trick or Cong comeback



FILM: PG 12

'Not promoting infidelity'



823 seats, 5 states, 1 big day

Early trends expected within hours; final results likely by day-end

VINAY KUMAR

NEW DELHI: All eyes will be on counting of votes today, polled in Assembly elections held across four states – Assam, Bengal, Tamil Nadu and Kerala – and one union territory Puducherry over the past one month,

High octane, high-stakes electoral battle has so far been witnessed in West Bengal with repolling announced in three constituencies – Falta, Diamond Harbour and Magrahat Paschim. The intense tussle to secure power is evident between the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) and Trinamool Congress (TMC) and the two parties have been pretty regular in the exchange of accusations and barbs flying both ways.

A total of 823 seats went to polls last month across the four states and a union territory. The elections have been held in multiple phases over the past few weeks. Results of West Bengal where chief minister Mamata Banerjee is vying for a fourth term and Tamil Nadu where the DMK is trying to retain power have the potential of redrawing opposition equations. Will the BJP, led by Prime Minister Narendra Modi, be able to fulfill its pan-India ambition? The results will also put the Congress under scrutiny. West Bengal saw a record voter turnout in two-phases of polling with several



Security personnel stand guard outside the counting centre at Netaji Indoor Stadium on the eve of counting and results of the West Bengal Assembly polls, in Kolkata, on Sunday

seats witnessing close contests.

Counting of votes is expected to start at 8 am under tight security arrangements, and the results are likely to be out by the end of the day. Trends are likely to emerge within the first few hours.

Counting starts with postal ballots, which include votes cast by service personnel, election staff and others unable to vote in person. After these are counted, officials move to the Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs). Each machine is opened in front of authorised officials and candidates' representatives, and it shows how many votes each candidate gets. In a first, the Election Com-

mission has introduced a QR code-based Photo Identity Card system through ECINET to prevent unauthorised entry into counting centres.

Votes will be counted across 77 centres for 293 assembly seats in West Bengal, which has witnessed unprecedented security deployment this time and an acrimony-filled run-up to the result day, with both the ruling TMC and opposition BJP expressing apprehensions of vote manipulation.

The two-phase polls in the state ended on April 29, with its highest-ever voter turnout of 92.47 per cent since Independence. The election was counter-

manded in one constituency - Falta - in South 24 Parganas district due to "severe electoral offences" and fresh polls will be held there on May 21.

The poll body has scaled down the number of counting centres this year to 77 from 87 announced earlier, and 108 in 2021, while putting in place a multi-layered security grid.

"Comprehensive security arrangements have been made to ensure that counting is conducted in a peaceful, transparent and orderly manner," a senior EC official said.

The EC has deployed 165 additional counting observers and 77 police observers. It has introduced stringent

TAKEAWAYS

» 823 seats contested across four states and one union territory over multiple phases

» Counting starts at 8 am under tight security; early trends expected within hours

» Postal ballots counted first, followed by EVM votes in presence of officials and candidates

» Election Commission of India introduces QR-code voter ID system for counting centres

access control measures at the counting centres, including banning mobile phones except for returning officers and observers.

The BJP-led NDA is hoping for a hat-trick in Assam. EVMs, holding the electoral fates of 722 hopefuls from 126 assembly constituencies of the state, will be opened at 40 counting centres across 35 districts.

Twenty-five companies (around 100 personnel each) of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) have been deployed to guard the counting centres and the strongrooms, housing the electronic voting machines (EVMs). Two additional CAPF companies will be kept on static duty, while 93 companies of state armed police have been deployed in

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DELHI'S DEADLIEST BLAZE THIS YEAR

Nine from 2 families killed as fire rips through four-storey building

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A predawn fire tore through a four-storey residential building in East Delhi's Vivek Vihar on Sunday, killing at least nine people, including a toddler, and injuring several others in one of the deadliest residential blazes in the Capital this year. The blaze broke out between about 3:13 am and 3:50 am in Vivek Vihar Phase-I and quickly spread across multiple floors, trapping residents inside as thick smoke filled the building and escape routes became blocked. Officials said an air-conditioner blast is suspected to have triggered the fire, though the exact cause is still under investigation.

Police said they received a PCR call in the early hours and rushed to the spot along with senior officers. Firefighters, disaster management teams and other emergency personnel joined the operation. A total of 12 fire tenders were deployed, and it took more than five hours to bring the fire under control.

The flames spread rapidly, especially in the rear part of the building, affecting flats from the first to the fourth floors. Many residents were trapped inside as smoke filled staircases and corridors. Around 10 to 15 people were rescued during the operation. Firefighters had to use ladders and even cut through iron grills to reach those who



A fireman in the four-storey residential building where a fire killed at least nine people, at Vivek Vihar area, in New Delhi, on Sunday

HIGHLIGHTS

» Blaze broke out between 3:13 am and 3:50 am in four-storey building in Phase-I

» Fire spread rapidly from rear, engulfing flats from first to fourth floors

» Thick smoke filled corridors; staircase access blocked, residents trapped inside

» Preliminary probe suggests possible air-conditioner blast triggered fire

» Twelve fire tenders deployed; blaze controlled after over five hours

» Around 10-15 residents rescued; grills cut and ladders used in operation

» Building had single staircase, locked terrace door, grilled balconies hampering escape

could not get out.

Nine people were confirmed dead, most of them from two families. Five members of one family living on the second floor were identified as Arvind Jain (60), his wife Anita Jain (58), their son Nishant Jain (35), daughter-in-law Anchal Jain (33), and their one-and-a-half-year-old

child, Akash. Another family on the third floor also lost their lives, including Nitin Jain (50), his wife Shailey Jain (48), and their son Samyak Jain (25). On a lower floor, Shikha Jain (45) was also killed in the fire.

Several people were injured. Two with minor injuries were taken to Guru Teg Bahadur

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Canada declares Khalistan extremists as 'national security threat'

OTTAWA: Canada's intelligence agency has declared Khalistani extremists a "national security threat", adding that the group uses institutions to promote its "violent extremist agenda" in the country.

Canadian Security Intelligence Service, in its 2025 Public Report, highlighted that involvement of Canada-based Khalistani extremist (CBKE) in violent activities "continues to pose a national security threat to Canada and to Canadian interests."

"Some CBKEs are well connected to Canadian citizens who leverage Canadian institutions to promote

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'I am one of the six victims': Vinesh Phogat speaks ahead of wrestling comeback

NEW DELHI: Wrestler Vinesh Phogat has publicly confirmed that she is among the six women who filed sexual harassment complaints against former Wrestling Federation of India chief Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, just days before her return to competitive wrestling at the National Open Ranking Tournament in Gonda. In a video message shared on Sunday, Phogat said she had earlier chosen not to speak due to the ongoing legal proceedings but felt



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IRAN STANDS FIRM ON STRAIT OF HORMUZ ISSUES

Iran presses for end to war within 30 days as Trump expresses doubts

KEY POINTS

» Iran's 14-point plan counters US nine-point plan

» Proposal demands sanctions removal, blockade end, troop withdrawal, halt to hostilities

» Includes stopping Israel operations in Lebanon

» Iran sent response via Pakistan intermediary

» Pakistan previously hosted Iran-US negotiations



- » Trump earlier rejected Iranian proposal; talks still ongoing
- » Fragile three-week ceasefire currently holding

ASSOCIATED PRESS

DUBAI: Iran's latest proposal to the United States calls for issues between the two countries to be resolved within 30 days and aims to end the war rather than extend the ceasefire, according to Iran's state-linked media.

President Donald Trump said on Saturday that he was reviewing a new Iranian proposal to end the war, but also expressed doubt it would lead to a deal.

Iran's 14-point proposal calls for an end to the war, rather than just an extension of the truce. The proposal, a rebuttal to the US nine-point plan, also calls for the US to lift sanctions on Iran, ending the naval blockade, withdrawing forces from the region, and ceasing all hostilities, including Israel's

operations in Lebanon, according to the semi-official Nour News agency, which has close ties to the country's security organisations.

Iran sent its reply via a Pakistani intermediary, the news agency reported. Pakistan has hosted previous negotiations between Iran and the United States. Trump rejected a previous Iranian proposal this week. However, conversations have continued, and the fragile three-week ceasefire appears to be holding.

Also on Sunday, Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi spoke with Oman's Foreign Minister Badr al Busaidi, who oversaw previous rounds of talks between the US and Iran before the latest round of fighting.

The US president also offered a new plan to reopen

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ISSUES ALERTS IN MULTIPLE STATES

IMD forecasts rain, thunderstorms in north India over next few days

Rains in several northern states provide relief from heat

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The India Meteorological Department has predicted widespread rain, thunderstorms and gusty winds across north India over the next few days, issuing multiple alerts while indicating a gradual dip in temperatures in several regions.

In Delhi, the IMD has placed the city under a yellow alert for the next two days, warning of thunderstorms, rain and gusty winds. Cloudy skies and intermittent showers are expected to continue until May 6. The Safdarjung Observatory recorded a minimum temperature of 24.6



A cart puller moves through on a rainy day, in Rishikesh, Uttarakhand, Sunday

degrees Celsius on Sunday, a notch below normal, as rainfall

helped ease heat conditions. Uttarakhand remains under close watch, with the IMD issuing an orange alert for Dehradun, Haridwar, Tehri, Pauri, Nainital, Champawat and Udham Singh Nagar. These districts are likely to witness isolated heavy rainfall, hailstorms and intense spells of precipitation, accompanied by gusty winds reaching speeds of 40 to 50 kmph. The department has forecast light to moderate rain and thunderstorms across all districts on Monday and Tuesday, along with snowfall in areas above 4,000 metres. Maximum temperatures in the state are

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India's largest privately built satellite 'Drishti' launched aboard SpaceX rocket

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Bengaluru-based space start-up GalaxEye on Sunday successfully launched its Mission Drishti satellite aboard Falcon 9 developed by SpaceX from California, marking a milestone for India's private space sector and drawing praise from top political leaders. The satellite is described as the world's first OptoSAR platform, combining electro-optical and synthetic aperture radar

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CENTRAL LOCKING, IRON GRILLS, SINGLE STAIRCASE TURN FATAL IN DELHI RESIDENTIAL BUILDING FIRE

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Central locking systems, thick iron grills at the back of the building, and a single staircase that served as the only internal escape route turned fatal when a massive fire tore through a residential building in Delhi early Sunday, leaving nine people dead.

The fire, suspected to have been triggered by an air-conditioner blast, broke out around 3.48 am in the four-storey building in Vivek Vihar Phase-I and rapidly engulfed flats on the upper floors on its rear side, trapping residents inside as smoke and flames spread through the structure.

With the electricity supply disrupted amid the fire, residents said centrally locked doors may have become difficult to open, while the lift became unusable. At the rear, thick iron grills and enclosed balconies further complicated the evacuation and rescue process, they added.

"There is one central staircase which serves as both the entry and the exit. The rear side gate was covered with a grill, which we had to cut using tools," a firefighter involved in the operation said.

He added that to rescue around 15 people, the team

deployed ladders from different sides and used a turntable ladder vehicle.

The building had parking space on the ground floor, eight flats above it with four each on the front and back sides, a lift adjacent to the staircase, servant quarters, and a narrow rear gate opening into a cramped back lane lined with adjoining structures and overhead wires.

Describing the rescue efforts, Sanjeev Rana, member of a non-profit disaster management team, said, "We received a call around 6 am. When we went upstairs with the fire department personnel, we first saw one charred body on the second floor, then five bodies on the next floor. After that, we moved to the top floor."

On the top floor, three people had tried to save themselves but could not escape because the door leading to the rooftop had a central locking system, he said.

Those found dead on the fourth floor were identified as Nitin Jain (50), his wife Shailey Jain (48), and son Samyak Jain (25), police said.

"They could not get out. The bodies of the mother and son were found holding each other on the staircase leading to the roof. The sight was devastating," Rana said.



tating," Rana said. Neighbours said Nitin was involved in the paper trade in Chawri Bazar and also owned a restaurant in Karkardooma. His younger son, Prasuk, aged around 22, survived as he had travelled to Ujjain with friends.

On the third-floor flat, five members of another family -- Arvind Jain (60), his wife Anita Jain (58), their son Nishant Jain (35), daughter-in-law Anchal Jain (33), and their grandchild, Akash Jain -- were found dead. "Arvind and Anita were

widely known in the locality because they maintained close ties with everyone," a resident said, adding that their son Nishant worked as a chartered accountant in Connaught Place, while their daughter-in-law was employed in a private

bank. The couple had a child after eight years of marriage, neighbours said.

They added that Arvind's household comprised nine members, including his younger son Deepak, his wife Sonali, and their two sons aged four and five.

Sonali, Arvind's daughter-in-law, said, "It is my son's fifth birthday today. We had booked rooms in Manesar for the celebration and rushed back after hearing the news."

"My sister-in-law, brother-in-law, and their baby were supposed to come yesterday, but there was a change of plan, and they decided to come today instead," she lamented.

Meanwhile, on the second floor where the fire is suspected to have originated, a woman, identified as Shikha Jain (45), was found dead. Her husband Naveen Jain (48) suffered burn injuries while attempting to come down the staircase, residents said. "Naveen came down using the stairs and got burnt. We rushed to the side of the building to rescue their two daughters, aged around 21 and 23, who were standing on the edge of the balcony. We spread mattresses below and used ladders to bring them down," a resident said, adding that both sustained minor leg injuries

because of the jump. Another survivor, Silky, said that she, her husband, two children, and in-laws remained stranded on a front-side balcony on the top floor until firefighters reached them with a hydraulic ladder.

"We stayed on the balcony for a long time. If they had not rescued us within five minutes, we too would have died," she said. Eyewitnesses said the fire appeared on the rear side of the second floor before racing upwards to the third and fourth floors.

"The fire started on the second floor at the back. After that, it spread to the third and fourth floors. We live on the upper ground floor and ran downstairs immediately," said Rakesh, another resident.

"I got a call saying a fire has broken out. We came down the stairs, but soon after we exited, the staircase got blocked. Glass started falling, and there was fire everywhere," he added.

Rana from the disaster management team said several air-conditioners were installed in the house, and an AC blast may have triggered the fire.

"When we went upstairs, we saw two ACs even in the drawing room. If one blasted and furniture were nearby, that could have made the fire spread faster," he said. WITH AGENCY INPUTS

Delhi L-G, CM condole loss of lives

NEW DELHI: Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta condole the loss of lives in the fire tragedy in east Delhi's Vivek Vihar and said immediate medical assistance and relief are being provided to the affected people.

"Deeply saddened by the tragic fire incident in Vivek Vihar Phase-I. My thoughts and prayers are with the families who have lost their loved ones in this devastating tragedy," Sandhu said in a post on X.

"I pray for the speedy recovery of the injured and strength for the bereaved families during this difficult time," he said.

The L-G said the authorities have been directed to ensure that all necessary medical assistance is provided to the injured, along with immediate relief and support to those affected. In a post on X, Chief Minister Gupta said the situation is being constantly monitored. The incident was "extremely" tragic and distressed her a lot, she said. She said the injured are being treated in a nearby hospital. MP0ST



Greater Noida clears ₹6,048 crore Budget

DIIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: Greater Noida Authority on Saturday approved a Rs 6,048 crore Budget for 2026-27 and unveiled a series of key decisions focused on infrastructure expansion, public relief, and improved connectivity during its 143rd board meeting.

The budget maintains a balance between estimated income and expenditure, with a major thrust on land acquisition, rural development, and infrastructure projects. Around Rs 1,150 crore has been allocated for land acquisition, while Rs 2,176 crore will be spent on construction and development works such as roads, sewage treatment plants, substations, and public amenities.

The authority decided not to increase water charges this year, breaking the trend of a 10 per cent annual hike in place since 2013-14. It also introduced a one-time settlement (OTS) scheme, offering up to 40 per cent waiver on interest for those clearing pending water dues by June 30.

To boost regional connec-

tivity, the board approved two major road projects. A 15-km stretch will link the 105-metre road to the Ganga Expressway, while a six-lane elevated corridor parallel to the dedicated freight corridor will ensure smoother cargo movement to the upcoming Noida International Airport. Public transport is also set to improve with the rollout of 15 electric buses on four routes connecting key areas to the airport. Officials believe the service will gain traction once flight operations begin.

The authority also cleared an OTS scheme for flat allottees, offering relief on delayed payments, and approved a modest 3.58 per cent increase in property allotment rates.

Additionally, IIT Delhi will be tasked with preparing a plan to ease traffic congestion at Pari Chowk and nearby areas.

Other decisions include setting up a 220 kV substation in Ecotech-10, procuring high-rise firefighting equipment worth Rs 100 crore, and advancing carbon credit initiatives to support sustainability and revenue generation.

BANK OFFICIAL AMONG 3 HELD Fake trading app scam busted

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has busted an investment fraud racket and arrested three people, including a bank official, for allegedly duping a retired government officer of over Rs 45 lakh through a fake trading application, an official said on Sunday. With the latest arrests, the total number of accused held in the case has risen to five, he said. The accused have been identified as Kapil Bain (25) and Manoj Sharma (26), both residents of Udhampur Singh Nagar in Uttar Pradesh, and Kamal Pandey (24), a resident of Gadarpur in the same district, who was working as an assistant manager in a bank.

The case surfaced after a retired government official reported that he had been

cheated of Rs 45.33 lakh on the pretext of investing in the share market through a mobile application posing as a legitimate trading platform.

"The fraudsters impersonated representatives of reputed investment firms and lured the victim into investing in IPOs by promising high and assured returns. They used a professionally designed fake application and website to gain his trust," a senior police officer said.

Investigations revealed that the defrauded amount was routed through multiple mobile bank accounts, which were opened using economically vulnerable individuals, and quickly withdrawn after deposits.

Kapil Bain and Manoj Sharma allegedly operated these mobile accounts, where the cheated money was deposited

and withdrawn through cheques on the same day, the police said. The role of Kamal Pandey emerged during the probe. He allegedly facilitated the fraud by helping open mobile accounts, sharing sensitive transaction details and expediting withdrawals within bank premises, the officials said.

The arrests were made during a coordinated operation in Udhampur Singh Nagar following sustained technical surveillance. Bain and Sharma were traced first, while Pandey was later apprehended based on their inputs, they said.

The police said further investigation is underway to identify other syndicate members, trace the money trail and locate additional victims targeted through similar fraudulent platforms.

Dental surgeon takes own life

OUR CORRESPONDENT

FARIDABAD: After an argument with his wife, a dental surgeon allegedly died by suicide by jumping into the Agra Canal from the Sector 17 bridge in Faridabad, police said on Sunday. Upon receiving information about the incident, a team from the State Disaster Response Force (SDRF) arrived at the scene late Saturday night. After a search lasting 20 hours, the team recovered the doctor's body from the canal on Sunday, they added. According to the police, the deceased was identified as Sachin (36), a resident of Yadav Colony in Ballabgarh, who owned a dental clinic in the area.

On Saturday night, around

The police are currently investigating the motive behind the suicide by questioning the doctor's wife

9 pm, Dr Sachin was returning home with his wife and children after visiting his sister in Sector 87. An argument broke out between the couple during their journey, which intensified as they drove, police said.

Investigation revealed that following the dispute, Dr Sachin stopped his black Scorpio vehicle near the Sector 17 bridge and began walking toward the canal.

Despite his wife's attempts to stop him, he pushed her away and jumped into the water.

After the incident was reported, the Kheri Pul police station team arrived at the location and called in the SDRF for assistance. The team conducted a search by boat for several hours. Ultimately, after a 20-hour operation, they recovered Sachin's body from the canal and transferred it to the mortuary, police stated.

"Dr Sachin's body has been recovered from the Agra Canal after an extensive search. The police are currently investigating the motive behind the suicide by questioning the doctor's wife," said Inspector Devender Kumar, SHO of the Kheri Pul police station.

Cops crack 26-year-old murder case

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Crime Branch of the Delhi Police has arrested a 50-year-old man for the sensational murder of a man about 26 years ago.

An anonymous source tipped the Crime Branch of the Delhi Police about the criminal. The accused has been identified as Naresh Mukhiya alias Nageshwar, resident of Samastipur Village, Bihar. According to the police, the accused a proclaimed offender since October 2000, was apprehended from Bihar's Samastipur district following sustained efforts and technical surveillance.

The case pertains to an FIR dated January 13, 2000, under Sections 302 and 392 of the Indian Penal Code.

Police said the accused had



been on the run since committing the crime and had frequently changed locations to avoid arrest. His capture marks a significant achievement in tracking long-pending heinous cases. According to investigators, the incident took place in January 2000 at a residential building in Indra Vihar, Delhi, where Mukhiya was employed.

He learned that a resident, Asha Chhabra, had recently sold a property and was keep-

ing a large amount of cash at her home. Mukhiya, along with his associates, conspired to rob the money and eliminate any resistance.

On the day of the crime, the accused and his accomplices entered the victim's house and began searching for valuables.

When Chhabra discovered them, she raised an alarm. Mukhiya and his associates overpowered her, and he strangled her using a telephone

cord, killing her on the spot. The group then fled with approximately 8 lakh rupees in cash and other valuables.

The breakthrough came when a special team led by Inspector Pukhraj Singh revisited unsolved cases.

Acting on specific intelligence developed by ASI Pardeep and Head Constable Narendar, police traced Mukhiya to his native village in Bihar. A coordinated raid conducted on May 2, 2026, resulted in his arrest.

Police revealed that Mukhiya had lived in multiple cities, including Siliguri, Kolkata, and Ahmedabad, during his years in hiding, before eventually returning to Bihar. He is currently being interrogated, and efforts are underway to trace his accomplices and recover remaining evidence.

Key Nandu gang member held in Rs two crore extortion case

NEW DELHI: A key associate of gangster Kapil Sangwan was arrested in connection with an extortion demand of Rs 2 crore, an official said on Sunday.

Kaptaan alias Tanna, 33, is an important member of Sangwan's gang — also known as Nandu gang — and has been evading arrest for over a year.

The case pertains to an extortion bid in which gangster Kapil Sangwan allegedly demanded Rs 2 crore from a Delhi-based resident. When the victim refused to pay, gang members conducted reconnaissance of his house and recorded videos to intimidate him.

"Kaptaan played a key role in the conspiracy by supplying illegal arms and facilitating plans to open fire at the complainant's residence," a senior police offi-

cer said. The case registered at Chhawla police station last year under relevant sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act.

The breakthrough came following a tip-off received on Friday about Kaptaan's movement in Deerpur, after which a trap was laid and he was successfully apprehended, the police said.

Another gang member was caught earlier while allegedly conducting a reconnaissance of the victim's house. He revealed the involvement of other gang members, including Kaptaan, and plans to use guns, they said.

Kaptaan is a habitual offender with a criminal history spanning over a decade and has been previously involved in around 10 cases, including murder, attempt

to murder, robbery, extortion and violations of the Arms Act across Delhi and the NCR, the police said.

Investigators said he began his criminal activities in 2012 with allegedly stealing vehicles and later joined a gang before working with the Nandu gang through Dara Singh alias Dhara. "He played an active role in several violent crimes, including firing incidents linked to extortion attempts in Najafgarh and surrounding areas," the officer added. Kaptaan was a resident of Najafgarh.

Further interrogation is underway to identify other associates and trace the supply chain of illegal arms linked to the gang. Police are also probing his role in other pending cases, officials said. AGENCIES

City Briefs

US-RETURNED MAN ENDS LIFE AFTER MARITAL DISPUTE

GURUGRAM: A 45-year-old man who had recently returned from the US died allegedly by suicide after jumping from the eighth floor of a high-rise building in Sector 65 here, police said on Sunday. The deceased, Nishant, a resident of M3M Emerald Hills Society, had come to Gurugram on April 28 after allegedly becoming depressed following a dispute with his wife, police said. No suicide note was found at the scene, they said. The man had been married for 12 years and was working in the US with his wife while his parents reside in Gurugram. Preliminary investigation revealed that Nishant had been facing marital issues, which reportedly led to depression. He returned to Gurugram and allegedly took the extreme step on Saturday evening at around 7.30 pm, by jumping from his society building, police said. Police reached the spot upon receiving information and sent the body for a post-mortem examination, after which it was handed over to the family. A senior police officer said that a probe is underway, adding that the family has not blamed anyone for the incident so far.

DELHI CONGRESS PROMISES SUPPORT TO BANJARA COMMUNITY

NEW DELHI: Delhi Congress president Devender Yadav on Sunday assured the Banjara community of support in raising its issues, accusing the BJP-led Delhi government of neglecting the community. Addressing a convention of Banjara community delegates at the Delhi Congress office, Yadav said the community had made significant contributions to Delhi's social and economic life but had remained marginalised in recent years. He alleged that the past governments in Delhi had failed to address the concerns of the community, including housing, livelihood and representation. "The Banjara community is an integral part of Delhi's landscape and cultural diversity. Their issues deserve urgent attention," Yadav said. He said the Congress, when in power in Delhi, had provided the community recognition and representation, besides addressing several welfare concerns. Yadav said members of the Banjara community, traditionally known for trade and transport of goods in earlier times, continue to contribute through small businesses and manufacturing of iron and aluminium utensils and tools.

Challan clock starts: 45 days to respond

CM Rekha rolls out new challan system

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push to tighten road discipline and ensure timely compliance, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday unveiled a new, fully digital and time-bound system for settling traffic challans, warning that delays will now invite stricter penalties and restrictions.

Announcing the reform, the Chief Minister said the new framework is aimed at curbing violations and improving road safety through transparency and accountability. "This will ensure better compliance with traffic rules and help reduce road accidents," she said, urging citizens to follow norms and settle challans on time.

Under the revised system, motorists will have 45 days to either pay the challan or challenge it online before a grievance redressal officer by submitting relevant documents. If no action is taken within this period, the challan will be deemed accepted, and payment must be completed within the next 30 days.

Importantly, violators seeking to challenge a challan in court will first have to deposit 50 per cent of the amount after exhausting the grievance process.

This will ensure better compliance with traffic rules and help reduce road accidents: CM



HIGHLIGHTS

- Under the revised system, motorists will have 45 days to either pay the challan or challenge it online before a grievance redressal officer by submitting relevant documents
- If no action is taken within this period, the challan will be deemed accepted, and payment must be completed within the next 30 days
- Importantly, violators seeking to challenge a

Rules, 1989, making the system more stringent and technology-driven. Repeat offenders will face tougher action, with those committing five or more violations in a year being classified as serious offenders, potentially leading to suspension or disqualification of driving licences. Challan issuance will now be fully modernised. Police and authorised officers can issue challans both physically and electronically, while violations captured through cameras and surveillance systems will automatically generate e-challans. These will be delivered within three days via mobile, or within 15 days through physical notice.

Officials said all challans will be recorded sequentially on an online portal to



City Briefs

DEEPLY SHOCKED: COURT QUESTIONS DELHI POLICE ARREST FROM BIHAR

NEW DELHI: A court here expressed shock over Delhi Police arresting a murder accused from Bihar without obtaining transit remand, saying the procedure adopted appeared to be an attempt to circumvent legal safeguards. Judicial Magistrate Apoorv Bhardhwaj was hearing an application filed by Delhi Police seeking two days of custody remand of Mukesh, who was arrested from Darbhanga in Bihar, and Anil in the murder case. "I am deeply shocked at the procedure adopted by the investigating agency. Seems that the accused was apprehended in Bihar and his arrest was delayed till he was brought to Delhi only to circumvent the procedure of obtaining transit remand," the judicial magistrate said. Noting that Mukesh was apprehended in Darbhanga and brought to Delhi, the court asked the investigating officer (IO) to explain through the concerned DCP why the accused was not formally arrested in Bihar and why transit remand was not obtained before bringing him to the national capital. "Prima facie this conduct only amounts to tweaking the law to suit the investigating agency's convenience. The Hon'ble High Court of Delhi has laid down comprehensive guidelines to be followed in the (case of) inter-state (arrest)," the court said.

SFI ALLEGES CURTAILMENT OF DISSENT AT JAMIA AMID ROW OVER VC'S REMARKS

NEW DELHI: The Students' Federation of India (SFI) unit at Jamia Millia Islamia has raised strong objections following protests at MMA Jauhar Hall during an annual function, where students demonstrated against remarks attributed to the university's Vice-Chancellor, Mazhar Asif. In a statement issued on Sunday, SFI expressed solidarity with the protesting students, who raised slogans criticising the VC over his reported "Mahadev DNA" comment made at a separate event. The student body termed the remark "unscientific" and "deeply problematic," arguing that such statements are inconsistent with the values of scientific temper and inclusivity expected in a central university. According to SFI, the protest at MMA Jauhar Hall was a "legitimate expression of dissent," with students voicing concerns over what they described as an increasing ideological influence on campus.

Delhi Metro Phase V(B): 97 km, 65 new stations

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major push to expand urban mobility, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday announced an ambitious Phase V(B) expansion of the Delhi Metro, aimed at connecting the city's fast-growing outskirts with the core network. The project, unveiled on the 32nd Foundation Day of the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), will add over 97 km of new lines and 65 stations across seven corridors, at an estimated cost of Rs 48,204.56 crore.

Calling it a transformative step for the Capital, the Chief Minister said, "This entire project will connect Delhi's outlying and rapidly developing areas to the metro network, thereby providing people with enhanced facilities for fast, safe, and convenient travel." Out of the seven corridors, four have been identified as priority routes and will be fast-tracked for completion by 2029. "We have set a target to complete these priority corridors by 2029," Gupta said, adding that the remaining corridors will be developed in phases.

Among the key routes, the Dhansa Bus Stand-Nangloi corridor will span 11.859 km with nine elevated stations, improving connectivity in Najafgarh and adjoining areas. The Central Secretariat-Kishangarh corridor, covering 15.969 km, will largely run underground and connect key zones such as RK Puram and Jawaharlal Nehru University. The Samaypur Badli-Narela extension will bring North Delhi's outer regions into the metro fold, while the Kirti Nagar-Palam corridor will link key residen-



NETWORK BOOST

- The project, unveiled on the 32nd Foundation Day of the DMRC, will add over 97 km of new lines and 65 stations across 7 corridors, at an estimated cost of Rs 48,204.56 cr
- This entire project will connect Delhi's outlying and rapidly developing areas to the metro network, thereby providing people with enhanced facilities for fast, safe, and convenient travel: CM Rekha Gupta

NDMC SUVIDHA CAMP: Citizens air 101 grievances

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) organised a Suvidha Camp at the NDCC Convention Centre on Jai Singh Road, receiving 101 public grievances and facilitating direct engagement between citizens and civic authorities.

The camp functioned as a single-window platform for addressing complaints, sharing information, and improving access to civic services within the NDMC jurisdiction. According to officials, the grievances largely pertained to departments such as Civil Engineering, Horticulture, Public Health, Enforcement, Taxation, and Estate. A notable feature of the initiative was the opportunity for face-to-face interaction between residents and officials, enabling several issues to be resolved on the spot. Cases requiring further intervention were documented,

with clear timelines communicated to ensure transparency and accountability.

More than 100 officers from over 30 departments were deployed, with dedicated help desks operating under the supervision of departmental heads

More than 100 officers from over 30 departments were deployed, with dedicated help desks operating under the supervision of departmental heads

with clear timelines communicated to ensure transparency and accountability.

NDMC plants saplings, hears civic voices

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a distinctive outreach initiative, the New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) on Sunday combined environmental action with civic engagement by organising a tree plantation drive alongside a public grievance hearing at Babu Dham Housing Complex in Chanakyapuri.

Led by NDMC Vice Chairman Kuljeet Singh Chahal, the programme was held under the #EkPedMaaKeNaam on Sunday campaign, inspired by Prime Minister Narendra Modi's call to encourage citizens to plant a tree in their mother's name.

KEY POINTS

- What set the event apart was its integrated approach to governance
- While residents planted saplings and pledged to care for them, officials from multiple departments including Civil, Electrical, Road, Sewerage were present to address civic complaints on the spot

What set the event apart was its integrated approach to governance. While residents

Lifeline: Delhi Metro turns 32

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Celebrating the 32nd Foundation Day of the Delhi Metro Rail Corporation (DMRC), Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday lauded the Metro as the "lifeline" of the national capital, highlighting its journey from a challenging beginning to becoming a global benchmark in urban transport. The event was attended by Union Minister of State for Housing and Urban Affairs Tokhan Sahu, senior DMRC officials and members of the Metro workforce.

Addressing the event as chief guest, Gupta praised the dedication of Metro employees, officers and staff, crediting them for building a system known for efficiency and discipline. "Metro has become the capital's lifeline and a benchmark of efficiency and discipline," she said, adding, "Today, the word 'Metro' itself has become synonymous with reliability."



In a new initiative, Gupta proposed setting up 'cloth banks' at Metro stations to promote recycling and generate employment for women through self-help groups.

Reflecting on its growth since 1995, the Chief Minister noted that the network has expanded to 416 km, operating 343 trains across 303 stations and serving over 6.5 million passengers daily. "It is now difficult to imagine Delhi without the Metro," she said, underscoring its role in shaping daily life in the city. In the middle of her address, Gupta highlighted ongoing and future expansion plans, announcing that preparations are underway for seven new corridors under Phase V (B), which will further strengthen connectivity across Delhi. She also noted that work under existing phases is progressing rapidly, with continued support from the Centre.

Focusing on sustainability, the Chief Minister said the Metro plays a key role in tackling pollution and has already helped reduce over 600,000 tonnes of carbon emissions. She emphasised that strengthening public transport remains central to Delhi's environmental strategy.

Heat holds, rain hints ahead

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The day remained warm in the national capital on Sunday with the maximum temperature recorded at 36.6 degrees Celsius, even as the India Meteorological Department issued a yellow alert predicting thunderstorm with rain in the coming days.

Light rainfall was recorded in parts of the city in the last 24 hours, with Safdarjung logging 0.6 mm rain, Palam 0.7 mm and Ridge 0.6 mm, while Lodhi Road and Ay Nagar recorded trace rainfall. Among key stations, Safdarjung recorded a maximum temperature of 36.6 degrees Celsius, which was 2.7 degrees below the season's normal and 2 degrees lower than the previous day. Palam recorded 35.5 degrees Celsius, 4.6 degrees below normal. Lodhi Road recorded 35.1 degrees Celsius, 2.9 degrees below normal. Ridge recorded 35 degrees Celsius, 5 degrees below normal.

Palam recorded 22.4 degrees Celsius, 3.2 degrees below normal; Lodhi Road recorded 23.4 degrees Celsius, 0.4 degrees above normal; Ridge registered 23.5 degrees Celsius, 1.5 degrees below normal, and Ay Nagar logged 23.4 degrees Celsius, 0.2 degrees below normal.

The IMD has forecast thunderstorms with rain on Monday under a yellow alert, which means the residents should stay updated. The minimum temperature is expected to hover



Ayanagar recorded 35.8 degrees Celsius, 5 degrees below normal. The minimum temperature at Safdarjung settled at 24.6 degrees Celsius, 0.1 degrees below normal.

"No heatwave conditions are likely over Delhi during the next few days. Thunderstorm activity with rain and generally cloudy skies is expected to continue till May 6, followed by partly cloudy conditions till May 9," an IMD official said. The city's Air Quality Index (AQI) stood at 175, falling in the 'moderate' category. As per the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB) standards, an AQI between 0 and 50 is considered 'good'; 51 and 100 'satisfactory'; 101 and 200 'moderate'; 201 and 300 'poor'; 301 and 400 'very poor'; and 401 and 500 'severe'.

OFFERS HOPE

AIIMS develops technique for spinal deformity surgery

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA

NEW DELHI: A surgical technique pioneered at AIIMS, Delhi has emerged as a major breakthrough in the treatment of patients suffering from severe and complex spinal deformities, significantly improving outcomes in cases once considered extremely high-risk.

Developed by Dr Bhavuk Garg and his team from the orthopaedic department at AIIMS over the past seven years, the modified surgical



approach has brought new hope to patients with spinal deformities, who earlier had limited treatment options and faced a high probability of complications during corrective surgery, the hospital said in a statement.

The technique is a refined version of posterior vertebral column resection (PVCR), regarded globally as one of the most complex spinal deformity correction procedures.

The AIIMS, Delhi modification was detailed in an international scientific publication in 2020. According to doctors, the modified method preserves certain posterior spinal elements until later stages of surgery, improving spinal stability during correction and potentially reducing neurological and other life-threatening complications associated with conventional procedures.

Patients with severe deformities often present with twisted spines, chronic pain, breathing difficulties, inability to stand upright and severe psychological and social distress, doctors

said. "In the past, these surgeries were feared because of the possibility of major neurological or life-threatening complications. Today, with better technique and experience, outcomes have improved remarkably," a senior doctor said. Doctors said refinements in surgical planning, execution and peri-operative care have substantially enhanced safety outcomes and recovery rates in such complex cases.

Several patients, who earlier struggled with routine activities such as walking, sitting comfortably or attending school and work, have been able to resume normal lives following surgery, they said. Families of patients described the transformation as life-changing, saying the procedure restored not only mobility but also confidence and dignity.

The AIIMS-developed technique has also attracted attention from spine surgeons outside India, further strengthening the country's growing reputation in advanced orthopaedic and spinal care, the statement by the hospital said.

FIRST VISIT TO CARIBBEAN NATION

EAM Jaishankar arrives in Jamaica on official visit

KINGSTON: External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar has arrived in Jamaica on his first visit to the Caribbean nation to boost bilateral relations between the two countries.

Jaishankar arrived in Kingston on Saturday evening on the first leg of his nine-day tour of Jamaica, Suriname, and Trinidad and Tobago to further bolster India's strategic and cultural ties with the Caribbean nations.

"Pleased to arrive in Kingston for my first visit to Jamaica. Touched by the warm welcome extended by Foreign Minister @kaminajsmith," Jaishankar posted on social media.

He was welcomed by Jamaica's Minister of Foreign Affairs and Foreign Trade, Kamina J Smith, on his arrival in Kingston.

"Look forward to engaging with the Jamaican leadership, business community, and members of the Indian diaspora over the next two days," he said.

Bhopal: Director of IAS coaching institute held captive, robbed of Rs 1.89 cr

OUR CORRESPONDENT

BHOPAL: The Crime Branch in Madhya Pradesh capital Bhopal has arrested six persons for allegedly robbing an IAS coaching institute director of Rs 1.89 crore at gunpoint after holding her captive for two days, an official said on Sunday.

A police statement said the accused lured Shubhra Ranjan, director of a Delhi-based IAS academy, to Bhopal on Wednesday under the pretext of opening a new centre and organising a seminar.

"They invited her to a rented house, held her hostage using armed accomplices, and forced the transfer of Rs 1.89 crore into various bank accounts under threat to life. The accused organised a Sundry darkened recital at the place to ensure the victim's call for help would not be heard," the state-



EAM S Jaishankar being received by his Jamaican counterpart Kamina J Smith upon his arrival in Kingston PTI

"Looking forward to welcoming Minister S Jaishankar to Kingston as his first stop in the Caribbean, and the first Bilateral visit of an Indian External Affairs minister to Jamaica. The work continues as we strengthen cooperation between our countries at the bilateral, hemispheric and

multilateral levels," Smith had posted on social media before Jaishankar's arrival.

Jaishankar is expected to have bilateral engagements and interactions with prominent business leaders and members of the Indian community in Jamaica.

During his nine-day tour,

Highlights

- » Jaishankar arrived in Kingston on Saturday evening on the first leg of his nine-day tour of Jamaica, Suriname, and Trinidad and Tobago
- » Jaishankar is expected to have bilateral engagements and interactions with prominent business leaders and members of the Indian community in Jamaica

AGENCIES

India rejects Nepal's objection to Kailash Mansarovar Yatra via Lipulekh Pass

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India on Sunday trashed Nepal's objection to conduct of upcoming Kailash Mansarovar Yatra through the decades-old route of Lipulekh Pass in Uttarakhand and asserted that such "unilateral artificial enlargement" of territorial claims is "untenable".

New Delhi's sharp reaction came hours after the Nepal foreign ministry issued a statement strongly objecting to India and China making preparations for the annual pilgrimage via Lipulekh Pass without consulting Kathmandu, which claims the region belongs to it.

Last week, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) announced that the annual Kailash Mansarovar Yatra will take place from June to August via two routes -- Lipulekh Pass and Nathu La in Sikkim.

Jammu-Srinagar Vande Bharat gets positive response in first two days

Officials say over 8,900 passengers travel on the route

OUR CORRESPONDENT

JAMMU: The Jammu-Srinagar Vande Bharat Express has received an enthusiastic response, with over 8,900 passengers travelling on the route in the first two days of operations, officials said on Sunday.

Passengers are paying Rs 730, excluding catering charges, for the journey, they said, asserting that the rail route is emerging as an affordable and comfortable travel option as airfares between the two cities range from Rs 4,000 to Rs 6,000.

According to railway officials, around 3,925 passengers travelled on the train on its inaugural day, while the number crossed 5,000 on the second day of operations on May 3.

The positive response is being seen as a boost to rail connectivity on the Jammu-Srinagar route, with the service offering a cheaper and convenient alternative to air travel, they said.



Workers take pictures at a platform during the launch of direct Vande Bharat Express train service between Jammu and Srinagar, in Ramban district PTI

The semi-high-speed train covers the distance between Jammu and Srinagar in about four hours and 45 minutes, offering a faster and more convenient alternative to road travel, officials said. "The service has become the preferred choice for thousands of commuters, tourists and local residents."

They said the train's modern amenities, including GPS-based passenger information systems and upgraded interiors, have added to its appeal.

To enhance the travel experience, IRCTC has introduced a special vegetarian Kashmiri menu on the route, they said. "Passengers can opt out of meals at the time of booking, with catering charges deducted from the fare. Food can also be purchased onboard, subject to availability".

Officials expressed confidence that occupancy would soon touch full capacity, citing growing demand for the service.

From Page 1

Fire

Hospital, which activated its emergency "Code Red" protocol. The hospital said three people with burn injuries arrived around 5 am, with one admitted and two treated in the emergency department.

Naveen Jain (48), a resident of the building, suffered serious burn injuries and is being treated at Safdarjung Hospital. His two daughters, aged 18 and 21, and his elderly mother managed to escape by jumping from a balcony. The daughters suffered leg injuries but are now out of danger.

Survivors described frightening scenes. Mayanak, who lives on the first floor, said he woke up to neighbours ringing his doorbell repeatedly. "When I woke up, I saw the back portion of the building was on fire. I somehow managed to escape. The entire staircase was blocked," he said. He added that people living in the rear flats were trapped because their balconies were covered with grills.

Another resident, Silky, said she and others waited on their balcony until help arrived. "The fire had reached our drawing room. We were saved by five minutes," she said.

Firefighters said the building's design made rescue difficult. It had only one staircase for entry and exit, and the terrace door was locked. After the electricity went out, doors could not be opened easily and the lift stopped working. "We had to cut through iron grills to reach those trapped," a firefighter said.

Some victims were found near the staircase leading to the terrace, suggesting they may have tried to escape upward but could not get through. "Had the terrace door been open, they might have survived," a firefighter said. Family members also raised concerns. Ankit Jain, brother of Nitin Jain, said they believe the family tried to reach the terrace but could not open it. "Their bodies were found on the staircase," he said.

Police have registered a case under section 106(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which relates to causing death by negligence. Officials said a detailed investigation is underway to find out exactly what caused the fire and whether there were safety lapses. They are also checking whether the building followed fire safety rules, including proper exits and emergency access. Initial findings suggest that flammable materials inside the flats and the structure of the building may have helped the fire spread quickly. Strong winds may also have made the situation worse.

The incident comes at a time when Delhi is seeing a rise in fire cases. Data shows that the Delhi Fire Services has attended 7,801 fire calls this year up to April 27, about 20 per cent more than the 6,511 calls during the same period last year. In April alone, there were more than 2,300 incidents, a 54 per cent increase compared to March.

Officials say higher temperatures, heavy use of air-conditioners and electrical appliances, and dry weather are contributing to the increase.

Lieutenant Governor V K Saxena and Chief Minister Rekha Gupta expressed grief over the loss of lives and said relief and medical help are being provided. Several political leaders visited the site and met the families later in the morning.

Iran presses

the Strait of Hormuz at the mouth of the Persian Gulf, where about a fifth of the world's trade in oil and natural gas typically passes.

Iran's deputy parliament speaker said on Sunday that Iran "will not back down from our position on the Strait of Hormuz, and it will not return to its pre-war conditions." Ali Nikzad, who has no decision-making power in parliament, made the comments while on a visit to port facilities on Iran's strategic Larak Island, located close to the narrowest part of the strait.

"The Strait of Hormuz belongs to the Islamic Republic of Iran," he said, adding that the country was working to compensate businesses and property damaged during the war, and that Trump's blockade plan was certain to fail.

Nikzad reiterated Iran's position that any ships not associated with the US or Israel will be able to pass after paying a toll. The US has warned shipping companies they could face sanctions for paying Iran in any form, including digital assets, to pass safely. Iran effectively closed the strait by attacking and threatening ships after the US and Israel launched a war on Feb. 28. Tehran later offered some ships safe passage via routes closer to its shore, charging fees at times.

The US has responded with a naval blockade of Iranian ports since April 13, depriving Tehran of the oil revenue it needs to shore up its ailing economy.

On Sunday, the second day of Iran's working week, the rial weakened further against the US dollar. In Tehran's Ferdowsi Street, the capital's main currency exchange hub, the dollar was trading at 1,840,000 rials. Analysts say there is a strong possibility the currency will slip further in the coming days.

The rial was trading at 1.3 million to the dollar in December, which at the time was a record low, and triggered widespread protests over the worsening economy. Markets in Tehran remain unstable, with prices of some goods rising daily.

According to reports published in Iranian media, several factories have not renewed contracts for workers after the Iranian New Year holidays, and significant numbers have lost their jobs.

Yusef Pezeshkian, the son and adviser of Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, wrote on Telegram that both the United States and the Islamic Republic see themselves as the winner of the war and are unwilling to back down.

The Norwegian Nobel Committee urged Iran to immediately transfer Jailed Nobel Peace Prize laureate Narges Mohammadi for medical treatment in Tehran after her health had sharply deteriorated.

The committee said it was in touch with Mohammadi's family and lawyer, and that the 2023 prize winner's life remains at risk without treatment by her dedicated medical team in Tehran.

Mohammadi fainted twice in prison on Friday in the northwestern city of Zanjan, her foundation said, and was admitted to a local hospital. Her lawyers have said she is believed to have suffered a heart attack in late March.

"Narges Mohammadi is imprisoned solely for her peaceful human rights work. Her life is now in the hands of the Iranian authorities," Nobel committee chair Jørgen Watne Frydnes said.

Mohammadi, 53, a rights lawyer who won the prize while in prison, was arrested in December during a visit to the eastern Iranian city of Mashhad and sentenced to seven more years in prison.

Canada declares

their violent extremist agenda and collect funds from unsuspecting community members that are then diverted toward violent activities," the report issued on Canadian Government's website on Friday said.

Khalistani extremist groups demand the creation of a sovereign state within India and are designated as terrorist organisations by New Delhi because of their involvement in separatist activities.

The report comes a year after the 40th anniversary of the bombing of Air India Flight 182, whose suspects were members of the CBKE groups. "It remains to this day the deadliest terrorist attack in Canadian history, with 329 people killed, most of them Canadians," it said.

The report, however, said that non-violent advocacy for the creation of a state of Khalistan is not considered extremism, and some Canadians participate in legitimate and peaceful campaigning to support the Khalistan separatist movement.

"Only a small group of individuals who use Canada as a base to promote, fundraise, or plan violence primarily in India are considered Khalistani extremists," it said.

The India-Canada relations hit rock bottom in 2023 when then Prime Minister Justin Trudeau alleged a potential Indian link to the killing of Sikh separatist Hardeep Singh Nijjar in Canada. India rejected the charges. Under Prime Minister Mark Carney, who took charge last year, India and Canada have sought to rebuild their bilateral ties.

AGENCIES

Vinesh Phogat

compelled to do so now as testimonies continue in court.

"I did not want to speak while the case is still pending, but I want to say that I myself am one of those six victims," she said, adding that the examination of witnesses is still underway. Phogat also referred to guidelines laid down by the Supreme Court of India regarding the protection of survivors' identity and dignity.

Her statement comes ahead of the May 10 to 12 tournament, which will mark her first competition since the Paris Olympics 2024 and her debut in the 57kg category. The event is also a key step in qualification for the 2026 Asian Games. Phogat had stepped away from wrestling following her disqualification in Paris and resumed training in recent months.

However, the 31-year-old has raised concerns about competing in Gonda, citing safety risks and the potential influence of Singh in the region. She warned that any untoward incident involving her, her team, or supporters would be the responsibility of the government. "The tournament is being organised at a place where his influence is strong," she said, questioning whether officiating decisions and scoring could be affected.

Phogat also spoke about the psychological strain of returning to competition in what she described as a hostile environment. "Competing at a place linked to him, where most people present may be associated with him, puts immense mental pressure on me," she said, adding that she was unsure if she could perform at her full capacity under such conditions.

Responding to her concerns, WFI president Sanjay Singh said the venue would not be changed and offered a personal assurance of safety. "If Vinesh is worried about her safety, I

take personal guarantee of that," he said, noting that referees approved by United World Wrestling would officiate and all bouts would be recorded to prevent bias. He also pointed out that participation in the Open tournament is optional. According to WFI sources, around 1,400 wrestlers have registered for the event, making any last-minute venue change impractical. "Why should we inconvenience such a large number of participants who have already made travel and stay arrangements," a federation official said.

Phogat, who was among the prominent faces of protests against Singh at Jantar Mantar in 2023, reiterated that she does not seek special treatment. "I only want that results should reflect the hard work of athletes on the mat," she said.

Now also a legislator from Julana representing the Indian National Congress, Phogat said she remains committed to returning to the sport "honestly" and winning medals for the country, even as questions over fairness and safety persist ahead of her comeback.

MPOST

Drishti

technologies into a single operational system, a capability achieved by only a handful of global players so far.

Mission Drishti integrates electro-optical (EO) sensors, which capture high-resolution imagery in daylight and clear skies, with synthetic aperture radar (SAR), which uses radar pulses to generate images regardless of weather or time of day. The company said this dual capability addresses long-standing gaps in Earth observation by enabling consistent and reliable data collection across varied environmental conditions.

Founder and chief executive Suyash Singh said the satellite has been successfully placed in orbit and the team is now focused on commissioning. "As we move through this phase, we are already witnessing strong global interest in the differentiated datasets enabled by our Opto-SAR payload," he said. The satellite is expected to support a range of applications including defence, agriculture, disaster response, maritime monitoring and infrastructure planning.

The launch follows five years of indigenous research and development, along with extensive environmental testing and performance validation. Lt Gen A K Bhatt (Retd), director general of the Indian Space Association, said the achievement lies not only in the technology but also in its downstream potential. He noted that combining optical and radar capabilities on a single platform allows persistent, all-weather intelligence, adding that timely, decision-grade insights are becoming central to the space economy.

Political leaders also welcomed the development. Prime Minister Narendra Modi described the launch as a major step in India's space journey and said it reflects the passion of young innovators contributing to nation-building. Union Home Minister Amit Shah congratulated the scientists and engineers behind the project, saying the satellite would transform how Earth is observed and showcase India's capabilities globally. Union Minister Jitendra Singh called it a significant milestone and noted that it is the largest privately built satellite in the country.

GalaxyEye said Mission Drishti will complement India's existing Earth observation network, which includes 29 active satellites listed in ISRO's recent annual report. The company plans to scale the mission into a con-

stellation of 10 satellites by 2030 to build a robust and sovereign Earth observation infrastructure.

IMD forecasts

expected to fall by 3 to 5 degrees Celsius over the next three to four days.

The forecast follows a sudden spell of severe weather on Sunday morning that lashed several parts of Uttarakhand with heavy rain and hailstorms, uprooting trees, blocking roads and disrupting electricity supply at multiple locations. Authorities have placed district administrations on high alert.

In Uttar Pradesh, the IMD said thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and gusty winds of 40 to 50 kmph, gusting up to 60 kmph, are likely at isolated places. Rainfall over the past 24 hours was recorded across the state, with central regions receiving up to 5 cm at isolated locations. Eastern districts saw light to moderate showers, while western parts reported light rain with thunder and lightning. Day temperatures remained below normal across the state, with a drop of 5 to 7 degrees Celsius in some areas. No heatwave conditions were reported, and none are expected over the next week. Amid the weather activity, one person died and another was injured in Sultanpur after a tree fell on a flour mill during a storm on Sunday morning, police said.

Chandigarh and parts of Punjab and Haryana also fall within the broader forecast zone of thunderstorms and gusty winds. Residents in Chandigarh woke up to dark clouds, followed by strong winds, a dust storm and sharp rainfall. Power supply was disrupted in some areas. Rain was also reported from Mohali, Rupnagar and Ludhiana, bringing a marginal dip in temperatures.

Chandigarh Power Distribution Limited said restoration work was ongoing. "Due to high wind speed and falling of power lines, the electricity supply in some of the areas has been affected for longer than expected. Our team is continuously working on the restoration of the supply," it said.

In Punjab's Hoshiarpur district, an industrialist was injured after a sudden squall uprooted electricity poles and trees in an industrial area. Phagwara and surrounding regions were also hit by dust storms followed by rain. In Haryana, rainfall was recorded in Panchkula, Ambala and Yamunanagar.

Himachal Pradesh is also under alert, with the IMD warning of thunderstorms accompanied by lightning and gusty winds of 40 to 50 km/h in Kangra, Kullu, Mandi, Shimla, Solan and Sirmour districts on May 4, and in Mandi and Shimla on May 5. Rainfall, thunderstorms and hailstorms were reported across several parts of the state, including Shimla and Dharamshala, over the past 24 hours.

In contrast, Rajasthan continues to grapple with high temperatures despite isolated weather activity. Phalodi recorded the highest maximum temperature at 44.8 degrees Celsius, followed by Chittorgarh at 43.4 degrees Celsius. Sri Ganganagar and Jaisalmer recorded 42.8 degrees Celsius each, while Kota registered 42.3 degrees Celsius. Bikaner, Ajmer and Churu recorded 42.2 degrees Celsius, 40.3 degrees Celsius and 40.1 degrees Celsius respectively, while Jaipur recorded 38.3 degrees Celsius. The IMD said light to moderate rainfall accompanied by thunderstorms and dust storms was recorded at isolated places in the state in the last 24 hours, even as heat persisted.

ONE LAKH PERSONNEL BEING DEPLOYED FOR SECURITY ON VOTE COUNTING DAY

TN polls: All arrangements in place for vote counting, says state CEO

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: All arrangements, including a comprehensive three-tier security plan, are in place for counting of votes on May 4 at the 62 designated counting centres across the state, Chief Electoral Officer, Tamil Nadu, Archana Patnaik has said.

Elections to 234 Assembly segments were held in the state on April 23.

The incumbent DMK regime has fought big to retain power, and its archival AIADMK has slogged to win power after five years as the principal Opposition party. Actor-politician Vijay-led TVK's entry into the electoral arena has made predictions about the winning prospects though and the Tamil nationalist Seeman's NTK is another factor in the polls.

The counting of votes will commence at 8 am with the

'Kerala poll turnout rises to 79.70% after inclusion of service voters' postal ballots'

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: Kerala's voter turnout in the April 9 Assembly elections has tentatively risen to 79.70 per cent after the inclusion of service voters' postal ballots, CEO Rathan U Kelkar said on Sunday.

Addressing a press conference here, Kelkar also outlined elaborate arrangements for the counting of votes scheduled for Monday.

He said the polling percentage for the Assembly election was 79.63 per cent, excluding postal ballots of service voters.

The chief electoral officer said 53,984 postal ballots had been issued to service voters, of which 20,028 had been received as of May 1.

"Service voters can submit postal ballots till before counting begins. We have directed the postal department that postal ballots received from service voters, including on Saturdays, Sundays, and holidays, should be handed over to the returning officers without delay," he said.

He said the receipt of service voters' postal ballots had increased the polling percentage by 0.07 percentage points.

"The present voting percentage, after including service voters' inputs, stands at 79.70 per cent on a tentative basis," he said.

Kelkar said the final turnout figure would be announced only after the Election Commission of India releases its official index card, usually 48 hours after counting.

TN polls: Will May 4 mark a turning point for women in state politics

Elections to the 234 Assembly constituencies were held on April 23

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHENNAI: The dust has settled on the polling booths across Tamil Nadu and the state now holds its breath for May 4 when the winners of an intensely fought election will be declared. While the headlines focus on the clash of political titans and the survival of Dravidian legacies, a quieter but more profound transformation is being measured in the electoral ledgers.

Elections to 234 Assembly constituencies were held on April 23, and the polled votes will be taken up for counting on Monday.

This year, a record-breaking 443 women stood as contesting candidates -- a stark climb from the numbers seen just a decade ago. Yet, as the talk of the Nari Shakti Vandan Adhiniyam and the promise of 33 per cent legislative reservation dominates national discourse, Tamil Nadu's own history reveals a journey that has been as much about regression as it has been about progress.

Highlights

» The counting of votes will commence at 8 am with the postal ballot counting and at 8.30 am, counting of votes recorded in EVMs will commence

» A total of 10,545 counting personnel have been drafted for counting duty

» A comprehensive three-tier security arrangement has been established at all counting centres

postal ballot counting and at 8.30 am, counting of votes recorded in EVMs will commence. Approximately 1.25 lakh personnel which includes officials, and micro-observers on vote-counting duty and police have been deployed.

Polling was held on April 23 in all the 75,064 polling stations for the Tamil Nadu Assembly election. For the purpose of counting votes recorded in Electronic Voting Machines (EVMs), 234 counting halls have been arranged.

An additional 240 halls have been designated for the

counting of Postal Ballots and Electronically Transmitted Postal Ballots (ETPBs). A total of 3,324 counting tables will be used for the counting of polled votes, Chief Electoral Officer Patnaik said in an official release.

The counting operations will be conducted by the Returning Officers (ROs) with the help of Assistant Returning Officers (AROs). A total of 10,545 counting personnel have been drafted for counting duty, supported by 4,624 micro-observers to ensure transparency and integrity of

the counting process.

Police sources said approximately one lakh personnel are being deployed for security on vote counting day.

The Election Commission has deputed 234 Counting Observers, one for each Assembly constituency, to oversee the counting proceedings and ensure strict compliance of norms.

For the counting of postal ballots, one counting table will be provided for every 500 ballots. In this regard, 1,135 additional AROs have been deployed.

A comprehensive three-tier security arrangement has been established at all counting centres to ensure the integrity and smooth conduct of the counting process.

Outer perimeter of 100 meters around each counting centre will be guarded by adequate police personnel. The second tier of security cover-

ing the entry gates of the counting premises will be secured by the State Armed police. The third tier covers the "innermost security layer," including the entrance to counting halls and the EVM strong rooms and here, the Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) will have authority.

In addition to the local police and State Armed Police, 65 companies of the CAPF have been deployed at the counting centres to further strengthen security arrangements. Further, as a first-time initiative, the Election Commission has introduced a QR code-based Photo Identity Card system through ECINET with the objective of preventing unauthorised entry into counting centres.

At the third and innermost security checkpoint, entry will be permitted only upon successful verification through QR code scanning.

Assam polls: Counting to decide BJP hat-trick or Cong comeback

EVMs will be opened at 40 counting centres across all 35 districts amid tight security arrangements

OUR CORRESPONDENT

GUWAHATI: The battle for Assam will enter its final stage with the counting of votes on Monday, determining whether the BJP-led NDA gets a third term or the Congress wrests power after weeks of wrangling marked by identity politics, welfare delivery and regional aspirations.

EVMs, holding the electoral fates of 722 hopefuls from 126 Assembly constituencies of the state, will be opened at 40 counting centres across all 35 districts amid tight security arrangements.

Among the contestants, 59 are women. Counting in Nagaon district will be held in three separate centres, while in Kokrajhar, Tinsukia and Jorhat it will be held at two centres each.

Twenty-five companies of Central Armed Police Forces (CAPF) have been deployed



Security personnel stand guard outside a strong room storing EVMs on the eve of counting of votes for the Assam Assembly elections, in Tezpur, Sunday

to guard the counting centres and the strongrooms, housing the electronic voting machines (EVMs).

The authorities will deploy 800 more unarmed police personnel to move the EVMs from strongrooms to the counting centres.

Chief Electoral Officer Anurag Goel had said that two additional CAPF companies will be kept on static duty. On the other hand, 93 companies of state armed police have already been deployed in the

districts, he said.

The support of 85 Assault Groups has also been sought on the counting day to deal with any untoward incident.

Polling in the state was held on April 9, with 85.96 per cent of the over 2.50 crore electorate exercising their franchise.

Among the 722 candidates, Congress has the highest 99, followed by BJP with 90, AIUDF with 30, NDA allies Asom Gana Parishad (AGP) with 26 and Bodo Peoples' Front (BPF) with 11 nominees.

BENGAL ELECTIONS

Akhilesh targets BJP over 'misuse of power'

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Samajwadi Party president and former Uttar Pradesh chief minister Akhilesh Yadav on Sunday weighed in on the West Bengal elections, expressing confidence that Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee will return to power with a strong mandate while accusing the Bharatiya Janata Party of misusing power and spreading misinformation.

Addressing a press conference at the party's state headquarters in Lucknow, Yadav alleged that the BJP has been running a targeted campaign based on fear and propaganda to influence voters. He claimed that what was witnessed during



Samajwadi Party president Akhilesh Yadav addresses a press conference, in Lucknow, Sunday

by-elections in Uttar Pradesh, including Rampur, was being replicated in West Bengal with the selective deployment of officials and heavy presence of central forces.

Yadav said the Election

Commission is a neutral constitutional body and people expect fairness from it, but alleged that the level playing field was compromised during previous bypolls. He claimed that similar patterns were now visible in West Bengal.

Launching a broader attack, Yadav said the BJP thrives on lies and layers one falsehood over another. He accused the ruling party of failing to control inflation and corruption, adding that profiteering by those close to the government has worsened the situation.

He said rising prices of petrol, diesel and cooking gas have triggered an increase in the cost of essential goods and transport, putting pressure on house-

hold budgets. According to him, common people are struggling due to the policies of the BJP government.

On the women's reservation law, Yadav alleged that despite its passage in Parliament, the BJP is misleading the public through false campaigns.

The SP chief also raised allegations of large scale corruption, particularly over the installation of smart meters.

He claimed that people are being overcharged and irregularities are widespread. Questioning the credibility of electoral systems, he said if manipulation is possible in smart meters, doubts about the safety of Electronic Voting Machines cannot be ignored.

Cong demands withdrawal of circular asking Haj pilgrims to pay Rs 10K more

NEW DELHI: The Congress on Sunday demanded the withdrawal of the Haj Committee of India circular raising the Haj airfare by Rs 10,000 per pilgrim and alleged that under the Modi government, the cost of performing Haj has risen to levels that place the pilgrimage beyond the comfortable reach of ordinary Indian families.

The Opposition party's demand came after the Haj Committee of India raised the Haj airfare by Rs 10,000 per pilgrim this year due to a sharp global rise in Aviation Turbine Fuel (ATF) prices. The Centre, however, asserted that the increase has been restricted through hard negotiations.

The Haj airfare hike has

drawn criticism from Opposition leaders, who have stated that such an increase amounts to "injustice".

A circular issued by the Haj Committee of India mentioned that in view of the extraordinary circumstances arising out of the ongoing crisis in the Middle East, a one-time revision in the airfare for Haj 2026 has been approved by the Ministry of Minority Affairs.

"The revised airfare entails an additional amount of USD 100 per pilgrim, irrespective of embarkation point, to be borne by the pilgrims. The decision has been taken in view of pressing requests from airlines for revision of base fare by more than USD 400 on account of the sharp

increase in Aviation Turbine Fuel prices due to the prevailing situation in the Middle East, after due examination of facts and consultation with stakeholders," the circular stated.

Accordingly, all Haj pilgrims this year are required to deposit Rs 10,000 towards the differential airfare by May 15, it added.

In a post on X, Congress MP and general secretary Syed Nasseer Hussain said that on April 28, 2026, the Ministry of Minority Affairs issued a circular demanding an additional payment from every Haj pilgrim, payable by May 15. He claimed that this demand was made without prior notice, without consultation, and without justification commensurate with its timing.

Govt in damage control mode after Rahul's Great Nicobar visit: Cong

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress General Secretary Jairam Ramesh on Sunday dismissed the Modi government's recent press note on the Great Nicobar Island Development Project, saying it fails to address serious ecological, tribal rights, and financial concerns raised by affected communities and experts.

Ramesh alleged the government is in "damage control mode" following Leader of Opposition Rahul Gandhi's April 28 visit to Great Nicobar. He contended the project violates environmental regulations and lacks democratic accountability.

On ecological grounds, Ramesh highlighted that Galathea Bay, the proposed port



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi during his visit to Great Nicobar Island, in Andaman and Nicobar Islands

site, is a Coastal Regulation Zone (CRZ) 1a area where port construction is prohibited. The bay hosts over 20,000 coral colonies and serves as the Northern Indian Ocean's most critical nesting ground for endangered Giant Leatherback turtles, he noted. The recent nesting season recorded approximately 1,000 nests at the site.

Ramesh questioned the government's inconsistent tree-felling figures. According to his statement, the number of trees to be cut has shifted from 8.52 lakh trees (May 2022) to 9.64 lakh (August 2025) to 7.11 lakh in the latest press release. "The Government does not know the number of trees to be cut," Ramesh alleged.



OUR CENSUS

OUR DEVELOPMENT

(First Phase of Census 2027)

Common queries on Self-Enumeration (SE) and their Answers (Part-2)

WHAT IS SELF-ENUMERATION?

Self-Enumeration is an online process in which you fill and submit your household details on the SE portal (se.census.gov.in) yourself, without waiting for an enumerator

- ❖ What are the benefits of Self-Enumeration?
 - Fill details conveniently
 - Ensures privacy
 - Makes the Census process faster and efficient
- ❖ How to log in to the Self-Enumeration portal?
 - Select State/UT
 - Enter name of head of the family, mobile number and email (optional)
 - Verify through OTP
 - Start Self-Enumeration
- ❖ How to mark the correct location of your house?
 - Select district/PIN code
 - Enter area/landmark
 - Zoom on map and mark location near your house (Do not worry if exact address is not displayed)
 - Correct location marking is necessary
- ❖ Can I edit my information later?
 - Yes, you can edit before final submission during State/UT SE period
 - After final submission changes can be done during enumerator's visit
- ❖ Can SE portal be accessed outside India?

No, this facility is available only within India's geographical boundaries
- ❖ What if an error is found after submission?

Correction can be made when the enumerator visits your house
- ❖ Can I save and complete the form later?

Yes, you can save progress and complete the form within the stipulated time

CBC 19108/13/0066/2627



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CensusIndia2027

BODY OF LAST MISSING PERSON RECOVERED

Madhya Pradesh cruise boat tragedy: Death toll climbs to 13



Family members of victims mourn after a body was brought to a hospital following its recovery from the Bargi Dam, in Jabalpur district

MPOST BUREAU

JABALPUR: The bodies of a five-year-old boy and his uncle were recovered from Bargi Dam in Madhya Pradesh's Jabalpur district on Sunday morning, raising the death toll in the cruise boat tragedy to 13, police officials said.

The boat, around 20 years old and operated by the state tourism department, capsized during a storm on Thursday evening.

"The bodies of Mayuram (5) and his uncle Kamraj (around 50), an employee of the Ordnance Factory in Khamaria, were found floating and were fished out of the dam," Bargi Sub Divisional Officer of Police Anjul Ayank Mishra said.

All 13 missing persons identified have now been accounted for, he said, adding the bodies

were sent to a government hospital for postmortem.

Teams comprising around 20 Army divers airlifted from Agra, along with personnel from the National Disaster Response Force, State Disaster Response Force and local divers, were involved in the search operation, the police said.

Of the 41 identified passengers on board the vessel, 28 were rescued after the incident,

according to the police.

The CCTV footage near the boarding point showed 43 people heading towards the boat, though the identities of 41 passengers have been confirmed so far, they said.

The state government on Friday ordered a probe into the incident and dismissed three crew members. It also banned the operation of similar vessels in the state.

HIGHLIGHTS

- » The boat, around 20 years old and operated by the state tourism department, capsized during a storm on Thursday evening
- » All 13 missing persons identified have now been accounted for
- » The bodies were sent to a government hospital for postmortem
- » Teams comprising around 20 Army divers airlifted from Agra, along with personnel from the NDRF, SDRF and local divers, were involved in the search operation
- » Of the 41 identified passengers on board the vessel, 28 were rescued after the incident

Saini woos OBC voters in Punjab

SWATI MAHAJAN

CHANDIGARH: With the Punjab Assembly elections less than a year away, Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini has intensified outreach to Other Backward Classes (OBCs), urging them to unite and support the BJP in the state.

Addressing gatherings in Ludhiana and Rupnagar on Sunday, Saini said the BJP has empowered OBC communities by providing leadership opportunities rather than treating them as a vote bank. He pointed out that the Union Cabinet includes 27 OBC ministers and that several BJP-ruled states have OBC chief ministers,

reflecting the party's commitment to inclusive governance.

Highlighting policy measures, Saini said the OBC Commission was granted constitutional status under BJP rule and that 27 per cent reservation has been ensured for OBCs in medical and higher education, expanding opportunities for youth. He also assured people of Punjab that welfare schemes implemented in Haryana would be extended to the state if the BJP comes to power.

Speaking at the Mahishi Kashyap Jayanti event, he described the Kashyap community as hardworking and capable of contributing significantly to societal development. He reiterated

the government's focus on inclusive growth under the slogan "Sabka Saath, Sabka Vikas, Sabka Vishwas."

Saini also targeted the ruling Aam Aadmi Party, alleging that it had failed to fulfil its promises and had disappointed the people of Punjab. He questioned the intent behind a special Assembly session called on Labour Day, calling it insensitive towards workers.

Calling for unity among OBC communities, Saini said their collective strength could shape the political future of Punjab. He urged them to mobilise at the grassroots level and support the BJP in the upcoming elections.

RPF rescues multiple minors across NFR stations



MPOST BUREAU

MALIGAON: The Railway Protection Force (RPF) of the Northeast Frontier Railway has carried out a series of rescue operations across its network, reaffirming its role in ensuring passenger safety and humanitarian assistance.

Between April 24 and April 30, RPF personnel rescued several vulnerable individuals, including runaway minors and distressed passengers, from railway stations and trains. In a major operation at Dibrugarh railway station, 12 minor boys were rescued from a train and later handed over to Childline authorities for care and protection.

Similar operations were conducted at stations such as Guwahati, Lumding, Kishanganj, Kokrajhar, Hasimara, Mariani and New Alipurduar, where several runaway boys and girls were traced. At Mariani, three minor girls were rescued, while at Guwahati, minors were reunited with their families following timely intervention.

In other cases, children rescued at Kishanganj, Lumding, Dimapur and Kokrajhar were handed over to Child Help Line and authorised agencies for rehabilitation.

In addition to rescuing minors, RPF personnel also extended prompt assistance to passengers in distress. At New Jalpaiguri, a passenger suffering from breathing difficulties was immediately shifted to a hospital for medical treatment.

In other instances, at Raiganj and Barsoi, injured passengers were provided timely medical aid after accidental falls, highlighting the alertness and responsiveness of RPF staff.

UP: IAF rescues 2 youths stranded atop water tank in Siddharthnagar

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: Two youths stranded atop an old water tank in Uttar Pradesh's Siddharthnagar district were rescued by an Indian Air Force helicopter early Sunday after a nearly 16-hour-long operation.

An Mi-17 V5 helicopter from the Central Air Command was deployed following a request from state authorities. The aircraft reached Kansiram Awasi Colony at around 5:20 am and completed the rescue in about 15 minutes. The two youths were airlifted to Gorakhpur.

Senior district officials, including the District Magistrate, Additional District Magistrate, Additional Superintendent of Police, Sub-Divisional Magistrate and Circle Officer Sadar, were present at the site. Teams

An Mi-17 V5 helicopter was deployed on the request of state authorities

from the electricity department, municipal body, district administration and the National Disaster Response Force were also deployed during the operation.

In a statement, the IAF said the youths had been stranded overnight after the ladder of the water tank was found damaged. It said the rescue mission reflected the force's swift response and commitment to saving lives. "The children were stranded in the night as the ladder of the water tank was damaged. The rescue mission, yet

again, displays the IAF's professionalism and commitment to save lives with a swift response in times of need," said the IAF in a social media post.

Initial attempts were made by authorities to create an alternative access route for NDRF teams to reach the site. However, rain-fall disrupted the effort, prompting officials to seek assistance from the Air Force.

The incident occurred on Saturday afternoon when five youths climbed the structure to shoot a social media reel around 1:00 pm. The ladder broke during the attempt, causing three of them to fall. One youth died while two others sustained injuries. The remaining two, identified as Pawan and Kallu, were left stranded on top of the tank. The deceased was identified as Siddharth.

New NCERT Class 9 book: Schools to teach Lata Mangeshkar's life struggles

'Would inspire young learners to value discipline, dedication and hard work'

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government's push to highlight the legacy of legendary singer Lata Mangeshkar has now found a place in school education, with her life and struggles being included in the Class 9 curriculum under CBSE.

The National Council of Educational Research and Training has introduced a new Hindi textbook titled 'Ganga' as part of the revised syllabus, which has been implemented across CBSE schools nationwide from the current academic session. The book places Mangeshkar alongside literary stalwarts such as Munshi Premchand, Ravidas, Tulsiadas, Suryakant Tripathi Nirala, Subhadra Kumari Chauhan and Mohan Rakesh.

Officials in the Education department said the move aims to introduce students to Mangeshkar's journey marked by perseverance, discipline and dedication, while also strengthening their language and creative skills.

The textbook includes a widely discussed interview of the singer conducted by author Yatindra Mishra, titled 'Aisi Bhi Baatein Hoti Hain' in the prose section. Spread across 12 pages, the interview presents an engaging account of Mangeshkar's life, her early struggles, musical training and eventual success in a simple and evocative style.

Educationist Rajendra Kumar said the inclusion of the chapter will play a crucial role in shaping students' understanding of perseverance and

KEY POINTS

- » The NCERT has introduced a new Hindi textbook titled 'Ganga' as part of the revised syllabus
- » Officials said the move aims to introduce students to Mangeshkar's journey marked by perseverance, discipline and dedication
- » The textbook includes a widely discussed interview of the singer conducted by



author Yatindra Mishra, titled 'Aisi Bhi Baatein Hoti Hain' in the prose section

excellence. "This chapter will not only introduce students to Lata Mangeshkar's struggles but also highlight her extraordinary achievements. It will inspire young learners to value discipline, dedication and hard work while helping them understand how challenges can be transformed into success through determination," he said.

The book also highlights the values she inherited from her father and the resilience that shaped her career. Officials said the inclusion of her life story will help students

TODAY'S CAUSELIST

SC to hear PIL seeking stricter Aadhaar issuance guidelines

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court is scheduled to hear on Monday a plea seeking a direction to the Unique Identification Authority of India to issue new Aadhaar cards only to citizens up to the age of six years, and frame stringent guidelines for its issuance to adolescents and adults to stop infiltrators from masquerading as Indian citizens.

As per the apex court's causelist of May 4, the plea would come up for hearing before a bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice Joy-malya Bagchi.

The Public Interest Litigation (PIL) filed by lawyer Ashwini Upadhyay has also sought a direction to the authorities to install display boards at common service centres stating that the 12-digit unique identification number is only a "proof of identity" and not a "proof of citizenship, address or date of birth."

Besides all the states and Union Territories, the plea has made the UIDAI -- which is the authority that issues Aad-



haar -- and the Union ministries of home, law and justice, and electronics and information technology as parties.

The plea, filed through advocate Ashwani Dubey, said Aadhaar, originally intended as a proof of identity, has increasingly become a "foundational document" enabling individuals to obtain other identification documents, such as ration cards, domicile certificates and voter identity cards.

"The UIDAI has issued 144 crore Aadhaar and 99 percent Indians have been enrolled. Therefore, the petitioner is filing this writ petition as a PIL under Article 32, seeking a direction to UIDAI to issue new Aadhaar to children only and frame new stringent guidelines for adolescents and

adults, so as to stop infiltrators from getting it and masquerading as Indian citizens," the plea said.

It said the need to file the plea arose when the petitioner came to know the manner in which infiltrators are able to procure Aadhaar through a verification process that is weak and can be easily manipulated.

"Foreigners apply for Aadhaar under the 'foreign' category. But infiltrators apply for Aadhaar under the 'Indian citizen' category and get it easily made. Thereafter, they obtain a ration card, birth and domicile certificate, driving licence, et cetera, essentially becoming indistinguishable from Indian citizens..." it said.

Besides seeking other directions, the plea has raised legal questions, including whether the Aadhaar Act 2016 has become "temporally unreasonable" for failing to keep up with the legislative intent of distinguishing foreigners from Indian citizens.

It said the alleged misuse of Aadhaar undermines targeted welfare delivery and leads to diversion of public resources.



Sri Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Act, 2026, which prescribes life imprisonment for sacrilege, claiming it has permanently addressed the issue.

Targeting rivals, Mann

accused Opposition parties, including the Shiromani Akali Dal and the Congress, of misrule, corruption and spreading propaganda to defame the state. He alleged that previous governments had diverted public funds for personal gains, whereas his administration ensured that taxpayer money is spent on welfare initiatives.

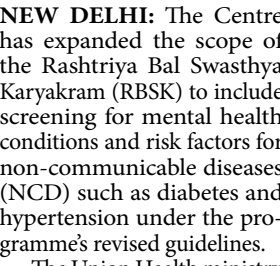
The Chief Minister said his government has prioritised development through investments in education, healthcare, infrastructure and employment. He claimed that over 65,000 jobs have been

provided without corruption and that free electricity has benefited nearly 90 per cent of households. He also highlighted the Mukh Mantri Sehat Yojna, under which families are entitled to free treatment up to Rs 10 lakh, adding that lakhs have already benefited.

Mann further criticised the Akali leadership over issues of drug abuse and past incidents of sacrilege, while accusing the Congress of internal divisions. He asserted that his government remains committed to transparent governance and people-centric policies.

Rashtriya Bal Swasthya Karyakram revamped

NOW INCLUDES MENTAL HEALTH, NCD SCREENING



NEW DELHI: The Centre has expanded the scope of the Rashtriya Bal Swasthya Karyakram (RBSK) to include screening for mental health conditions and risk factors for non-communicable diseases (NCD) such as diabetes and hypertension under the programme's revised guidelines.

The Union Health ministry released the RBSK 2.0 guidelines during the recently concluded National Summit on Good Practices and Innovations in Public Healthcare Service Delivery, marking a major overhaul of the flagship child health screening programme.

Building on more than a decade of implementation, the updated framework broadens the programme's established "4Ds" approach -- defects at birth, diseases, deficiencies and



developmental delays -- while incorporating emerging child health concerns, including behavioural disorders, mental health issues and lifestyle-related diseases.

The revised guidelines introduce a comprehensive preventive, promotive and curative continuum of care for children from birth to 18 years of age, with a stronger focus

on digitalisation and continuity of care.

According to the ministry, the enhanced screening framework aims to ensure early identification and timely intervention for a wider range of health conditions affecting children and adolescents.

Screening services under the programme will continue to be delivered through mobile health teams at anganwadi centres and schools to ensure wider outreach and universal coverage. The ministry said the new guidelines also seek to strengthen referral pathways from community-level screening to facility-based diagnosis and treatment through a robust referral tracking system aimed at minimising dropouts and ensuring follow-up care.

As part of the government's

digital health push, RBSK 2.0 introduces digital health cards, real-time data systems and integrated platforms for monitoring and service delivery.

"These digital innovations are expected to improve programme efficiency, accountability and evidence-based decision-making," the ministry said. The guidelines also stress greater convergence among the health, education and women and child development sectors to ensure coordinated service delivery through schools, anganwadi centres and community platforms.

The ministry said the revamped programme is expected to improve child health outcomes by strengthening early detection, referral systems and sustained follow-up care across the country.

Fire Safety Week: Pan-India event from May 4

NEW DELHI: The Union Health Ministry will observe a pan-India 'Fire Safety Week' from May 4 to 10 across healthcare facilities to strengthen preparedness and raise awareness on prevention and mitigation of fire hazards.

The week-long observance, being organised in collaboration with states, Union Territories and relevant central ministries and departments, will be inaugurated at Kartavya Bhawan here by Union Health Secretary Punya Salila Srivastava, a health ministry statement said on Saturday. A key highlight of the inaugural event will be the administration of a pledge on "Fire Safety in Health Facilities" by the health secretary, reaffirming commitment towards strict adherence to fire safety norms and preparedness measures in healthcare institutions, it said. During the observance, states and UTs will conduct awareness campaigns, mock drills, capacity-building exercises and dissemination of fire safety protocols.

Prasoon Joshi appointed Prasar Bharati chairman

NEW DELHI: Noted lyricist, writer and communications expert Prasoon Joshi has been appointed as the chairman of Prasar Bharati, India's public service broadcaster.

The Ministry of Information & Public Relations appointed Joshi to the key post, according to an official statement on Saturday.

Joshi, a distinguished creative professional with wide-ranging contributions across literature, advertising, cinema, and public communication, and known for his impactful writing and deep cultural sensibility, has played a significant role in shaping contemporary Indian media narratives, the statement said.

Joshi's body of work spans acclaimed film lyrics, advertising campaigns, and socially resonant storytelling that connects with diverse audiences across the country. On his appointment, Union Minister of Information & Broadcasting Ashwini Vaishnaw said: "My heartfelt congratulations to Shri Prasoon Joshi ji on his appointment as chairman of the Prasar Bharati Board. Prasoon ji is a rare creative spirit celebrated across the world in advertising, literature, art and cinema, yet his heart beats unmistakably for India."

Joshi has also served as CBFC chairperson

Vaishnaw said Joshi's words carry the fragrance of the country's soil, and his vision reflects the timeless essence of Indian culture. "Under his stewardship, Prasar Bharati will discover renewed energy, deeper purpose, and a fresh creative voice. My very best wishes to him for a memorable and meaningful tenure ahead," the minister said.

Before this appointment, Joshi has served as chairperson, Central Board of Film Certification (CBFC), Mumbai, since August 2017.

He contributed to strengthening film certification processes while engaging with stakeholders across the film industry and his tenure at CBFC reflected a balanced approach towards creative expression and regulatory responsibility, the statement said.

Earlier, he had also served as CEO, McCann World Group India and Chairman, McCann World Group Asia Pacific (a subsidiary of McCann Erickson).



EDITORIAL
CHOKEPOINT
CRISIS

Two months into the Iran war, the Strait of Hormuz remains less a waterway and more a question mark. Tanker traffic has thinned to a trickle, not because ships cannot physically pass, but because confidence has evaporated. In shipping, perception is as decisive as reality. A route that is technically open but strategically unpredictable might as well be closed. The Strait, which normally carries nearly a fifth of the world's oil consumption and a similar share of LNG trade, has long been described as the most critical maritime chokepoint on earth. Today, that description feels less like analysis and more like warning. The war has not merely disrupted supply; it has exposed how deeply the global economy remains tied to a narrow, vulnerable corridor that no amount of planning has truly replaced.

For decades, policymakers and energy strategists have spoken about diversifying away from Hormuz. On paper, those alternatives now exist. In practice, they are proving insufficient. Saudi Arabia's East-West Pipeline, stretching from the Gulf to the Red Sea, has emerged as the backbone of the workaround system. Built during the Iran-Iraq "Tanker War" of the 1980s, it was designed for precisely this kind of crisis. Yet even at its expanded capacity, it cannot replicate the volumes that normally pass through Hormuz. The bottleneck simply shifts downstream—to Red Sea terminals like Yanbu, which were never built to handle sustained emergency flows, and then onward to Egypt's Sued pipeline, whose limited capacity constrains how much oil can ultimately reach Europe. The system holds, but it strains. And the strain is visible in prices, in shipping premiums, and in the growing unease of markets that prefer predictability over improvisation.

If Saudi Arabia's infrastructure reveals the limits of scale, the experience of the United Arab Emirates reveals the limits of security. The Abu Dhabi Crude Oil Pipeline, which bypasses Hormuz entirely by exiting into the Gulf of Oman, should in theory offer strategic relief. In reality, it has become another target. Drone strikes on Fujairah—repeated, calculated, and disruptive—underscore a harsh truth: in modern conflict, geography offers only partial protection. Pipelines, terminals, and storage facilities are all within reach of relatively inexpensive weapons. The war has collapsed the old distinction between "safe" and "exposed" infrastructure. What was once considered redundancy is now merely another node in a network of vulnerabilities. The implication is stark: building more bypasses does not eliminate risk; it redistributes it.

For other Gulf producers, the situation is even more precarious. Iraq, whose exports depend overwhelmingly on southern terminals linked to Hormuz, has found its northern alternative through Turkey inadequate by comparison. Kuwait, entirely dependent on the strait, has been forced into contractual retreat, invoking force majeure as it struggles to maintain even baseline commitments. Qatar's vulnerability is of a different order but no less severe. Its dominance in LNG exports—supplying nearly a fifth of global trade—rests on a logistical reality with no alternative route. Gas cannot be rerouted through pipelines at scale; it must move by ship. And those ships must pass through Hormuz. The result is a cascading anxiety that stretches far beyond oil markets into fertilisers, shipping, and even industrial gases like helium, quietly critical to sectors ranging from healthcare to semiconductors.

What this crisis ultimately exposes is not a temporary disruption but a structural illusion. The belief that global energy flows can be meaningfully insulated from geopolitical shocks through infrastructure alone is proving misplaced. Building pipelines may ease pressure, but it cannot replicate the scale, flexibility, and cost-efficiency of maritime routes like Hormuz. Nor can it shield assets from the reach of modern warfare. The deeper lesson is that energy security in the 21st century cannot rely solely on physical redundancy. It must also account for political stability, technological resilience, and, increasingly, the unpredictability of conflict itself. As the war drags on and Hormuz remains uncertain, the world is being forced to confront an uncomfortable reality: some chokepoints are not just geographical—they are systemic. And escaping them will require far more than laying new pipes.

TALKING SHOP



RAJEEV NARAYAN
THE WRITER
IS A VETERAN
JOURNALIST AND
COMMUNICATIONS
SPECIALIST

Even as swanky homes in metropolises cost near or over \$1 million, India's cities nonetheless mask a dark truth; for the outward gloss camouflages a widening fracture in economic reality, one being witnessed worldwide as well

DIASPORA LENS



ASIF ULLAH KHAN
THE WRITER
HAS WORKED IN
SENIOR EDITORIAL
POSITIONS FOR
MANY RENOWNED
INTERNATIONAL
PUBLICATIONS

While global Indian business leaders often maintain calibrated neutrality on contentious issues, Mamdani represents a departure—linking identity with political positions, even at institutional cost

Gold-Plated Cities

India's luxury housing boom conceals inequality and asymmetrical creation of wealth, with overall shrinking affordability shrouded by piecemeal abundance

"Cities have the capability of providing something for each person, but only when they are created by and for everybody."

— Jane Jacobs

It begins with a quiet erosion and disappearance. Of space, access and balance. That is how, all but imperceptibly in India's most coveted urban addresses, the million-dollar dream is shrinking year after year. Even the most basic Google surfing shows that prime residential prices in India surged in 2025, reducing the square footage that US \$1 million (Rs 9.5 crore) can buy across top metros like Mumbai, Delhi and Bengaluru. Through the same year, these same cities climbed global luxury rankings.

The contraction may appear marginal — after all, just a few dozen square feet have been lost in each city — but the symbolism is profound. It signals that Indian metros are no longer peripheral players in the global luxury market. They are converging with it. In a world where Monaco offers 172 square feet for \$1 million, India's metros are moving towards that rarefied league. That very thin air of opulence.

Mind you, this is not about rising prices alone; it is about the changing meaning of urban space itself. A million dollars used to represent aspiration, the epitome of achievement, wealth creation and aggregation. Today, it is excruciatingly signifying something more. Exclusivity. Our cities, once sites of opportunity, are fast becoming gated arenas where entry is priced in millions. Of dollars.

Surge of Wealth

To understand the shift, look not at cities but at the people reshaping them. India's wealth story is no longer incremental; it is exponential. According to a Knight Frank Wealth Report, India has over 85,000 high-net-worth individuals and 191 billionaires, placing it fourth globally. This expanding affluent class is not static. It is young, entrepreneurial and increasingly global in its outlook. Projections suggest that the nation's ultra-high-net-worth population may grow by another 50 per cent in the next few years, while the broader affluent base may swell from 60 million to 100 million by 2027.

The consequences for real estate are immediate and dramatic. Luxury housing is no longer a niche segment, but the dominant force. In key markets, premium and ultra-luxury homes now account for more than half of new supply. In regions like Delhi-NCR and Mumbai (Metropolitan Region), they constitute over half of all new launches.

Developers, focused actors in a profit-driven ecosystem, are only smelling and following the money. High-end projects



Our cities, once sites of opportunity, are fast becoming gated arenas where entry is priced in millions

offer better margins, quicker absorption among affluent buyers and insulation from interest-rate volatility. The result is a structural pivot, one that moves away from affordable housing and toward towards aspirational enclaves designed for the elite. In the process, the skylines transform. Not gradually, but decisively. Towers grow higher, amenities grow more extravagant and the definition of 'home' shifts from shelter to statement.

Variegated Market

Yet, beneath this glittering ascent lies a disquieting trend, one that suggests that the market itself is tilting. According to property analysts, premium housing — homes priced above Rs 1 crore — accounted for 63 per cent of all sales in 2025, up sharply from 53 per cent in the previous year. At the same time, demand for homes priced below that threshold fell by a massive 31 per cent.

This is not a cyclical fluctuation, but a structural divergence. The housing market is no longer moving in tandem across segments. It is splitting into two distinct realities. While one is buoyant and wealth-driven, the other is constrained and receding fast — the numbers tell this stark story. Premium homes are being priced at thousands of times the average per capita income. This disconnect between asset prices and income levels is only widening. For the average Indian household, homeownership in major cities is simply slipping out of reach.

The consequences are becoming visible too. Urban rentals are projected to rise between 6 per cent and 15 per cent in FY 2026-27, far outpacing inflation. Resultantly, a growing share of the population is being pushed into long-term renting, effectively locked out of owner-

ship. In the words of an analyst who chose to remain unnamed: "Middle- and lower-income groups have been marginalised into a rental trap". This is the new urban equation: ownership for the few, tenancy for the most.

The Hidden Divide

The deeper paradox emerges when this housing boom is juxtaposed against India's broader economic trajectory. Recent IMF estimates show that India's GDP stands at around \$4.15 trillion in 2026, placing it sixth globally. While this underscores the country's economic heft, the per capita picture is far less flattering, with India ranking much lower globally on most income metrics.

This divergence between aggregate growth and individual prosperity is at the heart of the current moment. Wealth is being created but it is not being distributed evenly, and the rise of luxury housing is both a symptom and a driver of this imbalance.

Consider the structure of the market itself. At the end of March 2025, over half of India's housing inventory was concentrated in high-end and luxury segments, while affordable housing accounted for a fifth. This is not just a supply imbalance, but a reflection of priorities, market-driven and policy-led. When capital flows disproportionately into high-yield segments, the social function of housing begins to erode. Cities, in this context, quietly become islands of affluence surrounded by oceans of precarity.

Global Crosswinds

Overlaying this domestic imbalance is a volatile global environment. The ongoing tensions involving the United States, Israel and Iran have kept oil markets on edge, with prices oscillating sharply in

response to geopolitical signals. For India, a major oil importer, such volatility has cascading effects — it impacts inflation, fiscal balances and currency account stability. Historically, these pressures would cool real estate markets, particularly in urban centres.

But the luxury segment appears curiously insulated. Its drivers are not earnings or interest rates, but wealth accumulation and asset diversification. For the affluent, real estate is not just consumption, it is strategy. Some reports suggest that high-net-worth individuals allocate as much as 22-25 per cent of their wealth to residential property, underscoring its role as a preferred asset class.

In uncertain times, luxury real estate becomes a hedge; a tangible store of value in an unpredictable world. Yet, this insulation comes with a cost. It disconnects a critical sector of the economy from the lived realities of the majority.

Future Far From Even

What emerges is a portrait of an economy growing in two directions at once. On one axis, there is undeniable dynamism in rising wealth, expanding global integration and cities that command increasing global attention. On the other, there is a widening gulf between those who can participate in this growth and those who cannot. The risk is not just economic, but social and spatial. When housing becomes unaffordable, cities lose their integrative function. They cease to be melting pots of aspiration, hardening instead into segregated landscapes of privilege and exclusion.

For India, the path forward must reconcile these contradictions. Policy interventions must go beyond token incentives to address structural imbalances. Affordable housing needs not just subsidies, but systemic support such as land reforms, faster approvals and infrastructure that expands viable urban peripheries. Further, the focus must shift to income growth at the base of the pyramid. Without broad-based prosperity, any asset-driven boom will remain inherently fragile.

For the world, India's experience offers a telling lesson. Growth, when uneven, can distort markets and deepen divides even when headline indicators improve. Luxury booms may dazzle, but they can deceive too. The shrinking footprint of a million-dollar home is not only a statistic, but a signal too. It tells us that space in the world's fastest-growing cities is no longer about geography. It is about access, equity and the very idea of belonging. If India is to truly become a leading global economy, its cities must not only rise higher, they must open wider.

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Politics Of 'Being Seen'

Mamdani's invocation of the Kohinoor and Indian identity signals a deliberate political stance, where heritage becomes a tool to confront history

What sets New York Mayor Zohran Kwame Mamdani apart is not just his politics, but the ease with which he owns his Indian heritage. He does not deploy it selectively, nor reduce it to cultural nostalgia. He wears it openly — at a time when doing so in the United States is not without risk. In an environment shaped by the rhetoric of Donald Trump and emboldened white supremacist fringes, where Indians and other immigrants have increasingly found themselves in the line of fire, such visibility requires more than sentiment—it requires conviction.

Mamdani suggested to reporters that Britain should return the 105.6-carat Kohinoor diamond — which is set into the Queen Mother's crown and held in the Tower of London — to India. Mamdani said that if he met with King Charles III (he deliberately did not use "King" as he is opposed to the idea of monarchy) privately, he "would probably encourage him to return the Kohinoor diamond". Mamdani articulated a demand that many Indians, including those in positions of global influence, have hesitated to raise with similar clarity.

Mamdani's timing was notable, as on April 30 the United States returned a large collection of stolen artefacts to India, with 657 antiquities valued at nearly USD 14 million handed back following multiple investigations into international smuggling networks.

It was a deliberate choice — to raise a question of historical



In an America shaped by Trump's rhetoric — where immigrants have been vilified and religious identity politicised — Mamdani has chosen visibility over caution

justice in a space where most would choose silence. Mamdani's reluctance to engage privately with Charles was clear; his team distanced itself from the king from the moment the 9/11 ceremony at the World Trade Center was announced. "The mayor will not meet privately with King Charles. But the mayor will be at the wreath-laying ceremony," Joe Calvello, the mayor's press secretary, said. However, when Charles did meet Mamdani, the pair shook hands and smiled during a short conversation.

Mamdani does not fit easily into the template of a modern politician. Born in Uganda to Indian-origin parents, raised in the United States, and openly Muslim, he represents a layered identity that most public figures would try to simplify. He does the opposite because his middle name, Kwame, is an Akan masculine given name from Ghana (and Ivory Coast), meaning

"born on Saturday," commonly given to boys born on that day. Rooted in Akan culture, it signifies wisdom and leadership, often associated with strength, resilience, and being "combat-ready," and Mamdani appears to be living up to this name.

In an America shaped by Trump's rhetoric — where immigrants have been vilified and religious identity politicised — Mamdani has chosen visibility over caution. He speaks directly about immigration crackdowns, defends undocumented communities, and foregrounds his faith rather than softening it.

This is not the politics of comfort. It is the politics of risk.

Mamdani's campaign has also drawn on cultural memory, with occasional nods to Bollywood, such as using the opening lines "tumne kabhi kisi se pyaar kiya..." from the song *Om Shanti Om* in Karz starring Rishi Kapoor. This was not nostalgia, but more a loud assertion of

shared cultural identity.

But unlike the familiar diaspora instinct to celebrate culture in safe, apolitical ways, Mamdani connects identity to political questions: who belongs, who is excluded, and who gets to define both.

This is where the contrast begins to emerge. When PM Narendra Modi visits the United States, the images are strikingly consistent: prominent Indian-origin CEOs and businessmen greeting him warmly, offering praise, and reinforcing a narrative of India's global rise.

There is nothing inherently wrong with this; as business leaders, they have to engage with power.

On contentious issues — immigration policies in the United States, the surge in anti-Indian rhetoric, attacks on Hindu identity — figures such as Usha Vance have been frequent targets of the MAGA "alt-right" wing. Within that space, questions have even been raised about whether someone like Vivek Ramaswamy, a Hindu, could lead a largely Christian nation. Yet, on such issues, these same influential voices are often measured to the point of near silence. Their public posture is careful, their language calibrated. Prominent CEOs like Satya Nadella and Sundar Pichai have largely maintained a neutral stance.

Mamdani's call for the return of the Kohinoor diamond adds another layer to this contrast. At one level, it is symbolic—an intervention into debates about colonial legacy and restitution. At another, it raises a question:

who speaks about history, and from where?

It is difficult to imagine a corporate leader taking such a position publicly—not because the issue lacks merit, but because it complicates relationships with governments, markets, and carefully maintained neutrality. Mamdani disrupts that pattern. He does not treat identity as something to display, but as something to act upon—even when it is inconvenient.

Surprisingly, Mamdani, who was not born and brought up in India, and whose only connection to India is through his parents' DNA — who themselves spent much of their lives outside—has, in some ways, become more Indian than many Indians. When he took the oath of office, he began with Nehru's *Tryst with Destiny* speech. One of the telling markers of his Indianness was something as simple as eating biryani with his hands.

In a conversation with Mehdi Hasan, he said: "There is a persistent expectation in this country that to be a leader, you must shed the 'excess' of your heritage. When I eat with my hands, I am refusing to apologise for the way my ancestors have nourished themselves for centuries. I am not interested in a seat at the table if it requires me to leave my culture at the door..." Of course, Oprah Winfrey and many Republicans may not find this amusing. But he is not ready to shed his Indian roots because, as Javed Akhtar's line goes, "*Phir bhi dil hai Hindustani*." In his heart, Mamadani is *Hindustani*.

Views expressed are personal

THE FRAGILE THREE-WEEK CEASEFIRE APPEARS TO BE HOLDING

UK says bulk carrier reports attack near Strait of Hormuz

DUBAI: A bulk carrier near the Strait of Hormuz has reported being attacked by multiple small craft, the British military's United Kingdom Maritime Trade Operations center said Sunday, marking at least two dozen attacks in and around the strait since the Iran war began.

All crew aboard the unidentified carrier were safe after the attack off Sirik, Iran. The report warns vessels to transit with caution.

Iranian officials have asserted that they continue to control the strait and that ships not affiliated with the United States or Israel can pass if they pay a toll.

There was no immediate claim of responsibility for the attack.

The fragile three-week ceasefire appears to be holding, though President Don-

Highlights

» All crew aboard the unidentified carrier were safe after the attack off Sirik, Iran

» Iranian officials have asserted that they continue to control the strait and that ships not affiliated with the US or Israel can pass if they

pay a toll

» Iran's grip on the strait, imposed after the US and Israel launched the war, has shaken global markets



A tanker (left), and a car carrier are anchored at sea in the Gulf of Oman near the Strait of Hormuz

AP/PTI

ald Trump on Saturday told journalists that further strikes remained a possibility.

Trump has offered a plan

to reopen the Strait of Hormuz at the mouth of the Persian Gulf, where about a fifth of the world's trade in oil and nat-

ural gas typically passes, along with fertilizer badly needed by farmers around the world.

Iran's grip on the strait,

imposed after the US and Israel launched the war on Feb. 28, has shaken global markets.

Iran's deputy parliament speaker on Sunday said Tehran "will not back down from our position on the Strait of Hormuz, and it will not return to its prewar conditions."

Ali Nikzad, who has no decision-making power in parliament, spoke while visiting port facilities on strategic Larak Island.

Nikzad reiterated Iran's position that any ship not associated with the US or Israel can pass after paying a toll. Tehran effectively closed the strait by attacking and threatening ships.

The US has warned shipping companies they could face sanctions for paying Iran in any form, including digital assets, to pass safely.

AGENCIES

Trump's approval ratings dip ahead of midterms in Nov

WASHINGTON: Ahead of the midterm elections in November, US President Donald Trump's overall approval ratings have dipped to 37 per cent, and 66 per cent Americans do not appreciate his handling of economic issues, a poll has found.

The US President gets his best ratings for handling immigration at the US-Mexico border with 45 per cent approving of his policies, while 54 per cent expressed disapproval, according to the Washington Post-ABC News-Ipsos poll.

Large numbers of Americans say they trust "neither" political party to handle major issues, including 23 per cent who say this about immigration, 27 per cent on the economy, 28 per cent on crime and 33 per cent on inflation.

A slight majority (51 per cent) trusts neither Republicans nor Democrats to handle artificial intelligence.

The Iran war has dented the confidence of Americans in Trump's handling of economic issues, which were crucial to his political comeback in 2024.



US President Donald Trump

"A SLIGHT MAJORITY TRUSTS NEITHER REPUBLICANS NOR DEMOCRATS TO HANDLE ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE"

Americans disapprove of his handling of the situation with Iran by 66 per cent to 33 per cent. His rating on the economy has declined by seven points, to 34 per cent, as gas

prices have spiked.

His approval rating on inflation has fallen five points in that time to 27 per cent and his lowest rating comes on perceptions of his handling of the general cost of living, with 23 per cent approving vs. 76 per cent disapproving.

"Trump's overall approval now stands at 37 per cent, largely the same as the 39 per cent figure in February. But his disapproval has reached 62 per cent, the highest of his two terms in office," the Washington Post said.

AGENCIES

Israeli raid in West Bank leaves 1 Palestinian dead



Representational Image

NABLUS: One Palestinian man was killed and four others seriously wounded during an Israeli military raid in the Israeli-occupied West Bank city of Nablus on Sunday, the Palestinian Red Crescent said.

The Palestinian Health Ministry said the man's wife was in labour at a local hospital when she was informed of his death.

The Red Crescent said five people were hit by gunfire during an Israeli military operation. Nayef Firas Ziad Samaro, 26, was killed, according to the Health Ministry, and his body was brought to the hospital where his wife was giving birth. Additionally, a 12-year-old was shot in the shoulder, according to the Red Crescent.

The raid took place as schools were letting out for the day, in an area crowded with civilians, witnesses said.

Israel's military in a statement said it responded to a confrontation in the Nablus area in which several "terrorists" threw rocks toward soldiers. Soldiers fired and "several hits were identified."

Key Points

- » The Palestinian Health Ministry said the man's wife was in labour when she was informed of his death
- » The Red Crescent said five people were hit by gunfire during an Israeli military operation

Palestinians, rights groups and international observers are warning about the worsening violence, where young Palestinian men are being killed with increasing regularity amid a broader climate of arson, vandalism and the displacement of farming communities near Jewish settlements and outposts in the West Bank.

At least 42 Palestinians have been killed since the start of the year, according to the United Nations humanitarian office. Armed settlers were responsible for at least 11 of those fatalities.

AGENCIES

Imprisoned Iranian rights lawyer Narges Mohammadi at 'very high risk' in health crisis

BEIRUT: The health of imprisoned Iranian rights lawyer Narges Mohammadi was at "very high risk," her foundation and family said Saturday, adding that Iran's Intelligence Ministry was opposing her transfer to Tehran for treatment by her own doctors.

Mohammadi, a Nobel Peace Prize laureate in her early 50s, was urgently transferred to a hospital in Zanjan in Iran's northwest on Friday after a cardiac crisis and fainting. Her family has said her health had been worsening in part from a beating she received during her



Narges Mohammadi

December arrest.

Medical teams in Zanjan have requested her records before performing any treatment, while recommending that she be transferred to Tehran, her foundation said.

Medical teams in Zanjan have requested her records before performing any treatment

But her Paris-based husband, Taghi Rahmani, said the Intelligence Ministry opposed the transfer for angiography, or imaging of the blood vessels. He spoke in a voice message shared with The Associated

Press by the foundation. The Norwegian Nobel Committee in a statement urged Iranian authorities to immediately transfer Mohammadi to her medical team, saying her life is in their hands.

"She has the mental resilience for imprisonment, but her body does not have the readiness. The Ministry of Intelligence wouldn't even mind if (she) died," her husband told Sky News.

He added that their children hadn't seen Mohammadi for over a decade, since 2015.

AGENCIES

UK sets out fuel contingency plans for flights amid US-Iran conflict

LONDON: Airlines will be expected to consolidate schedules on certain routes with multiple flights to the same destination on the same day as part of contingency measures the UK government announced on Sunday.

The Department for Transport (DfT) issued a series of temporary plans amid ongoing jet fuel supply issues caused by the US-Iran conflict and the blockade of the Strait of Hormuz.

It stressed that while UK airlines say they are not currently facing supply issues, the government is stepping in to protect travellers from the likelihood of last-minute flight cancellations over the upcoming summer holiday period in the event of significant disruption caused by the conflict.

"Since the closure of the Strait of Hormuz, the govern-



ment has been monitoring jet fuel supplies daily and working with airlines, airports and fuel suppliers to stay ahead of any problems," said UK Transport Secretary Heidi Alexander.

"There are no immediate supply issues, but we're preparing now to give families long-term certainty and avoid unnecessary disruption at the departure gate this summer."

"This legislation will give airlines the tools to adjust flights in good time if they need to, which helps protect passengers and businesses," she said.

Alexander said that the UK "will do everything we can to insulate" the country from the impact of the situation in West Asia.

The contingency plans are designed to enable airlines to plan realistically and lock in schedules earlier so that people are less likely to be affected by short notice changes at the airport.

Instead of cancelling flights at the last minute, the temporary measures would help move passengers onto similar services, prevent running flights which have not sold a significant proportion of tickets and reduce wasted fuel from flying near-empty planes.

DfT said it will be consulting with the aviation industry in order to act quickly and before any travel disruption is allowed to take hold.

AGENCIES

'Paramilitary forces drone strike kills five in Sudan'

CAIRO: Sudan's paramilitary group, the Rapid Support Forces (RSF), killed at least five people in a drone attack that hit a civilian vehicle on the outskirts of Khartoum, a local Sudanese rights group said.

The attack on Saturday morning hit a vehicle that was travelling from the White Nile province to Omdurman, the sister city of the capital, Emergency Lawyers, a rights group tracking violence against civilians, said in a statement. It added that the attack reflects continued targeting of civilians on public roads and in populated areas.

Khartoum has largely been spared attacks by the RSF since it was recaptured by the Sudanese Armed Forces last year, but the capital has recently seen sporadic strikes.

The Rapid Support Forces, which have been at war with

The attack on Saturday morning hit a vehicle that was travelling from the White Nile province to Omdurman

the Sudanese Army for over three years, did not immediately claim the attack.

Emergency Lawyers condemned the attack and held the RSF responsible. "What happened was a brazen violation of international humanitarian law," it said. At least 59,000 people have been killed in the war that broke out in April 2023, according to Armed Conflict Location & Event Data, an independent conflict-monitoring body.

AGENCIES

Morocco: 2 US service members missing after military drills

RABAT: Two US service members are missing in southwestern Morocco after taking part in annual multinational military exercises in the North African country, the United States Africa Command (AFRICOM) said Sunday. The US, Morocco and other countries participating in the African Lion exercise have launched a search and rescue operation, AFRICOM said.

"The incident remains under investigation, and the search is ongoing," it said in a statement. The incident happened on May 2 near the Cap Draa Training Area near Tan Tan, close to the Atlantic Ocean. The war games exercise started in April and runs across four countries.

AGENCIES

Nepal marks Press Freedom Day; report flags rise in violations

KATHMANDU: Nearly 100 incidents of press freedom violations were recorded in Nepal over the past year, according to a report released on Sunday, as the Himalayan nation marked World Press Freedom Day.

Various programmes were organised countrywide to observe the day.

Freedom Forum Nepal, an organisation working in the field of press freedom, released a report on press freedom violations on the occasion.

It noted that 97 incidents of press freedom violations, affecting 145 media persons and 20 media organisations, were recorded in Nepal between May 1, 2025, and April 30, 2026. This is higher than the 68 incidents of violations registered the year before.

Threats, attacks and obstruction of journalists have been on the rise lately, according to the report, which noted 28 threats and death warnings, 21 attacks, and 18 acts of obstruction reported during the past year. Besides, eight arson cases, five court cases and four arrests were reported dur-

Various programmes were organised countrywide to observe the day

ing the review period, it said.

On the occasion, the Federation of Nepali Journalists (FNJ) organised a rally in Mai-tighar Mandala here on the theme 'Shaping a Future at Peace: Promoting Press Freedom for Human Rights, Development and Safety'.

At the rally, National Human Rights Commission (NHRC) member Manoj Duwadi described press freedom and freedom of expression as vital to human rights.

He added that the NHRC always stands for the protection and promotion of human rights. Nepal Bar Association Chair Prof. Bijay Prasad Mishra assured of moral support in the legal remedy for any hindrance or obstruction of freedom of expression and press freedom.

AGENCIES

Cubans struggle to survive on pocket-size govt ration books as products dwindle

Several Cubans who lived through that period say current situation is worse

HAVANA: Jose Luis Amate Lopez hasn't had a customer in almost two weeks, not counting the scrawny brown kitten that slinks around the bodega where he works in central Havana.

The shelves once laden with goods during his childhood sat nearly empty in late April, with barely anything to offer the 5,000 clients who depend on the state-run store for subsidised food.

Government ration books that once provided for a healthy diet and kept families fully fed for a month are now shrinking.

As the economy collapses and prices soar, a growing number of Cubans find themselves unable to afford alternatives to state-run stores and struggle to subsist on meagre salaries in a socialist country of nearly 10 million where basic goods increasingly are sold in US dollars.

"No Cuban can truly survive on the products from the ration book anymore," Amate Lopez said.

Revolutionary leader Fidel



REPRESENTATIONAL IMAGE

Castro established the ration book — "la libreta" — in the early 1960s. It offered heavily subsidised goods ranging from milk to fish and even cigarettes. Cubans knew their assigned bodega would be stocked with everything they needed by the first of the month.

The ration book shrank during the "Special Period," when Soviet aid plummeted in the 1990s and deprivation hit Cuba. During that time, Cubans lost an average of 5 per cent to 25 per cent of their body weight, according to one study published in a medical

journal, with goods including bread, milk, eggs and chicken in scarce quantities.

Even so, many Cubans who lived through that period say the current situation is worse.

Amate Lopez recalled that his assigned bodega was so full decades ago that "you could barely walk." It's now an empty room with dusty old posters detailing the prices and amounts of nearly two dozen goods no longer available, including yoghurt, pasta and bars of soap. Two industrial freezers, once packed with meat and chicken, serve only to

Highlights

» A growing number of Cubans find themselves unable to afford alternatives to state-run stores

» The ration book shrank during the 'Special Period,' when Soviet aid plummeted in the 1990s and deprivation hit Cuba

keep Amate Lopez's water bottle cold. In April, the only items he had available to sell were rice, sugar and split chickpeas.

Cuban teens turning 15, a landmark birthday in Latin America, used to receive cake and several cases of beer. Now they only get 3 kilograms of ground beef. The government recently opted to celebrate those turning 65 by awarding them sardines, a bar of soap and a package of toilet paper. But Amate Lopez said he doesn't have those items.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

OVER 130 FOREIGN NATIONALS ARRESTED IN LANKA FOR CYBER FRAUD

COLOMBO: More than 130 foreign nationals were arrested in Sri Lanka for alleged cybercrime operations over the last two days, police said. The police actions are part of a wider crackdown on cross-border online fraud networks operating from the island nation. In a raid in Thalangama, a suburb of Colombo, the police arrested 37 Chinese nationals on Saturday. One of them was a woman, two of them did not have valid visas, and one did not possess a passport, according to the police. All of them were aged between 24 and 44. In a separate raid on Sunday, more than 100 people were arrested in Rajagiriya, another Colombo suburb.

PAKISTAN CLEARS DONKEY MEAT EXPORTS AFTER CHINESE FIRM WARNING

KARACHI: Pakistan has approved the export of donkey meat to China after a Chinese company warned it could shut operations, prompting intervention by the prime minister's office. The dispute involves the Hangeng Trade Company operating in Gwadar, a port city central to China-backed projects, where export approvals had been delayed for months, raising questions about bureaucratic difficulties affecting foreign-backed projects in Pakistan. Pakistan govt's decision comes amid buzz about PM Shehbaz Sharif's visit to China later this month for an investment forum. Hangeng Trade Company runs a slaughterhouse exporting donkey meat and hides to China.

Cabinet to soon clear ₹37,500 crore coal gasification incentive scheme

The proposed incentive scheme is aimed at accelerating surface coal and lignite gasification projects across the country

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Cabinet is likely to approve soon a Rs 37,500 crore incentive scheme to promote coal gasification projects, aimed at boosting clean energy production and reducing import dependence, sources said.

The coal ministry has already prepared a Cabinet note on the scheme to promote coal gasification projects, with a financial outlay of Rs 37,500 crore, they said.

The proposed scheme is aimed at accelerating surface coal and lignite gasification projects across the country, promoting self reliance by reducing import dependence on critical commodities such as LNG, urea, ammonium nitrate, ammonia, ammonium nitrate, ammonia, coking coal via DRI, methanol and DME, while enabling enhanced utilisation of domestic coal and lignite resources for fuels and chemicals production, and supporting the national target of 100 million tonnes coal gasification capacity by 2030. This is a unified scheme with



The scheme will promote self reliance by reducing import dependence on critical commodities such as LNG, urea, ammonium nitrate, ammonia, coking coal via DRI, methanol and DME

no categories, and the maximum financial assistance for a single project is Rs 3,000 crore, they said.

In the earlier financial incentive scheme for gasification projects the government has provided financial under three categories which included

the maximum incentive of Rs 1,000 crore per project for the private sector and Rs 1,350 crore per project for the PSUs, sources said.

According to an industry analyst, the government's renewed push for coal gasification comes in the wake of recent

Highlights

- » The scheme will enable enhanced utilisation of domestic coal and lignite resources for fuels and chemicals production
- » It will also support the national target of 100 million tonnes coal gasification capacity by 2030
- » India has one of the largest coal reserves of 401 billion tonnes, uniquely positioning it to leverage domestic resources for reducing dependence on imports

West Asia tensions that have exposed the country's vulnerability to disruptions in LNG, LPG and other hydrocarbon supplies, underscoring the need to diversify energy feedstock sources. The government is now positioning coal gasification as a strategic lever to convert domes-

tic coal into fuels and chemicals, reduce import dependence, and strengthen energy security at a time when global supply chains remain fragile.

India has one of the largest coal reserves of 401 billion tonnes, uniquely positioning it to leverage domestic resources for reducing the dependence on imports and building a clean, resilient energy economy.

Coal remains the backbone of India's energy sector, accounting for over 55 per cent of the country's energy mix. As the second-largest producer and consumer of coal globally, India's coal consumption is expected to grow significantly as its energy demands continue to rise.

Gasification presents a unique opportunity for India to unlock the full value of its vast domestic reserves through clean and efficient utilisation pathways by converting coal into syngas, enabling the domestic production of syngas or its downstream products such as chemicals, petrochemicals, fertilisers, power and DRI.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government plans to expand its central bank digital currency (CBDC)-based food subsidy programme to Chandigarh, Dadra and Nagar Haveli, and Daman and Diu by June, following its implementation on a pilot basis in Gujarat and Puducherry, official sources said.

Under the scheme, beneficiaries receive their Public Distribution System (PDS) entitlement as a digital token in a wallet issued through the Reserve Bank of India's CBDC framework, instead of collecting physical grain at a ration shop. "Once implemented effectively, this initiative could generate subsidy savings of around 4 to 5 per cent, while making delivery more transparent, targeted, and efficient. This could become a revolutionary reform in the way food subsidies are delivered," the official sources said.

The move seeks to address a longstanding weakness in the current distribution system, where beneficiaries often face stock shortages or receive less than their full entitlement if they arrive at the fair price shop or ration shop late in the monthly cycle, leaving them dependent on the dealer with little recourse.

Section 12 of the National

Under the scheme, beneficiaries receive their PDS entitlement as a digital token in a wallet issued through the RBI's central bank digital currency framework

Food Security Act provides for shifting toward more efficient delivery systems, including cash transfer and direct benefit transfer, in recognition of such gaps in physical distribution.

However, a plain cash or DBT transfer carries its own risks. If money is transferred directly into a beneficiary's account without restrictions, it may be spent on non-food items, undermining the food security objective that the subsidy is meant to serve, sources said.

CBDC is being positioned as a "middle path", the sources said. Being sovereign digital money issued and guaranteed by the RBI, it carries the same legal status as regular currency but can be programmed for a specific purpose - in this case, the purchase of eligible foodgrains such as wheat and rice.

The token functions some-

what like a digital coupon. The entitlement stays in the beneficiary's control, can be redeemed at a ration shop or any permitted outlet, and is programmed to reject purchases outside the approved category, sources said.

On access, beneficiaries with smartphones can use a digital wallet, those with feature phones can receive a redemption code, and those without any device can continue under the existing physical distribution channel, the sources added.

In the current pilot, the token validity period is set at one month, though this can be extended if needed. Officials indicated that a window of up to three months may be reasonable in principle, but extensions beyond that are not being considered.

The scheme also benefits fair price shop dealers. Under the existing system, dealers are paid only after dues accumulate.

Under the CBDC model, payment flows automatically into the dealer's wallet on each transaction, making settlement faster and more transparent, sources said. Dealer stock management also becomes more dynamic. If a dealer receives 1,000 tonnes and distributes 980 tonnes, the next allocation can be linked to actual offtake rather than a fixed schedule, preventing unnecessary inventory pile-up at the last mile.

Adnoc plans to fast-track growth plan with \$55 bn awards



DUBAI: The UAE's flagship oil company Adnoc announced plans to accelerate a growth plan with 200 billion dirham (\$55 billion) in project awards spanning upstream and downstream operations, following the its exit from OPEC on May 1.

The \$55 billion outlay, part of \$150 billion the company had earmarked in capital expenditure through 2030, is planned for the period 2026 to 2028 and will help Adnoc meet rising global energy demand, the government-owned company said in a statement on Sunday.

"Adnoc is entering a defining execution phase in its strategy, driven by scale, pace and a laser-focus on delivery," UAE Minister of Industry and Advanced Technology and Adnoc chief executive officer Sultan Al Jaber said in the statement.

The UAE announced its departure from the oil cartel as of this month, saying the shortages caused by the Iran war will require agility to respond to market demands without being constrained by the collective decision-making process of the wider group, Bloomberg reported. The UAE's OPEC departure deals a significant blow to the group, and comes after years of tension with its leader Saudi Arabia. AGENCIES

India-bound tanker carrying liquefied petroleum gas clears Strait of Hormuz

NEW DELHI: A tanker carrying liquefied petroleum gas (LPG) for India has sailed out of the Strait of Hormuz and is now headed towards the country, an official statement said on Sunday.

The Marshall Islands-flagged LPG carrier MT Sarv Shakti, loaded with 46,313 tonnes of LPG and staffed by 20 crew, including 18 Indians, cleared the key shipping chokepoint on May 2 and is expected to reach Visakhapatnam on May 13, it said.

The cargo -- enough to meet half a days requirement of the country -- will partly tide over supply constraints being faced since the start of the West Asia conflict more than two months back.

Ship-tracking data showed its position in Oman Gulf on Sunday evening.

The very large gas car-



rier has previously made runs between the Persian Gulf and Indian ports, has been chartered by state-owned Indian Oil Corporation (IOC).

Sarv Shakti is the first India-linked tanker to cross the war zone since a weeks-old US blockade of ships tied to Iran began, pushing transits through Hormuz back down to almost zero.

There are as many as 14 Indian flagged or India-owned vessels still stranded on the west side of the Strait of Hormuz.

The statement said no incident involving Indian-flagged vessels has been reported in the past 24 hours. The Ministry of Ports, Shipping and Waterways is working closely with the Ministry of External Affairs, Indian missions and maritime stakeholders to ensure crew welfare and uninterrupted operations.

The Directorate General of Shipping (DG Shipping) control room has handled 8,373 calls and more than 17,965 emails since activation, including 38 calls and 127 emails in the last 24 hours.

India has also facilitated the repatriation of more than 2,953 seafarers so far, including 31 in the past day from across the Gulf region.

Port operations across the country remain normal with no congestion reported, the statement added. PTI

Automobile industry faces around ₹25 cr hit on profits for FY26 due to end-of-life vehicle rule

NEW DELHI: India's automobile industry could face a substantial hit of around Rs 25,000 crore to its FY26 bottom line due to the Environment Protection (End-of-Life Vehicles) Rules, 2025, which mandate provisioning for environmental compensation for vehicles sold in the past.

Industry executives said a seemingly minor clause—Rule 4(6)—in the notification issued by the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change in January 2025 has alarmed automakers after auditors flagged its wide-ranging implications.

The rule requires producers to meet Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) obligations for vehicles already sold, even if they cease operations.

This provision activates requirements under Ind AS 37, compelling automakers to set aside funds for EPR com-



pliance covering vehicles sold over the past 20 years for private use and 15 years for commercial use. Executives noted that such provisioning would be required regardless of whether companies plan to exit the market, effectively locking up capital and denting profitability.

Industry body Society of Indian Automobile Manufacturers has raised the issue with the government, highlighting the potential financial burden

once environmental compensation costs are notified by the Central Pollution Control Board. In a letter to the ministry, SIAM estimated a one-time gross impact of about Rs 25,000 crore, or roughly Rs 9,000 crore on a discounted basis, in FY26.

The industry had urged the ministry to amend Rule 4(6) to clarify that cumulative provisioning may not be necessary. However, the government's March 27, 2026 amendment

SIAM estimated a one-time gross impact of about Rs 25K crore, or roughly Rs 9K crore on a discounted basis, in FY26

retained the clause unchanged.

According to industry estimates, four-wheeler manufacturers may bear Rs 14,623 crore of the impact, while two- and three-wheeler makers could face Rs 9,650 crore.

Executives cautioned that once these provisions are reflected in financial statements, they could significantly reduce annual profits and constrain investments in new technologies and future growth initiatives. AGENCIES



layer message to the market: continuity despite the UAE's exit, and control despite limited physical impact," said Jorge Leon, an analyst at Rystad and former OPEC official.

"While output is increasing on paper, the real impact on physical supply remains very limited given the Strait of Hormuz constraints. This is less about adding barrels and more about signaling that OPEC+ still calls the shots."

Top OPEC+ producer Saudi Arabia's quota will rise

to 10.291 million bpd in June under the agreement, far above actual production.

The kingdom reported actual production of 7.76 million bpd to OPEC in March.

The seven members who met on Sunday were Saudi Arabia, Iraq, Kuwait, Algeria, Kazakhstan, Russia, and Oman. With the UAE leaving, OPEC+ includes 21 members including Iran. But in recent years only the seven nations plus the UAE have been involved in monthly production decisions, Reuters reported.

The Iran war, which began on February 28, and the resulting closure of the Hormuz strait have throttled exports from OPEC+ members Saudi Arabia, Iraq and Kuwait, as well as from the UAE.

Before the conflict, these producers were the only countries in the group able to raise

Punjab & Sind Bank aims to cross total biz milestone of ₹3L cr in FY27

NEW DELHI: State-owned lender Punjab & Sind Bank intends to achieve a milestone total business of Rs 3 lakh crore by end of the ongoing financial year helped by loan growth.

"We have achieved total business of Rs 2.63 lakh crore in FY26, registering a growth of 15 per cent and hope to cross Rs 3 lakh crore during the current financial year," Punjab & Sind Bank MD and CEO Swarup Kumar Saha said.

The bank is expecting a credit growth of 16-18 per cent and deposit expansion of 13-14 per cent in the ongoing financial year, he said.

With this kind of credit and deposit growth, he said, the bank can surpass Rs 3 lakh crore business mix, which is total of advances and deposits.

To meet the credit expansion, the bank is also planning to raise resources from both

equity and debt.

Punjab & Sind Bank is eying to mobilise up to Rs 3,000 crore via share sale on a private placement basis in a bid to meet the minimum public shareholding (MPS) norms of market regulator Sebi. As per Sebi norms, listed entities are required to have at least 25 per cent public shareholding.

Currently, the Government of India holds a 93.85 per cent stake in Punjab & Sind Bank.

"We have got board approval for raising up to Rs 3,000 crore from Qualified Institutional Placement (QIP) or other means (in FY27). We are in discussion with merchant bankers. We will soon start roadshows to engage with investors for proposed stake dilution," Saha said.

However, he said, timing and exact quantum would depend on market conditions, which are not very conducive

at present.

Besides, he said, the board has also approved Rs 3,000 crore infrastructure bonds and Rs 2,000 crore from Tier I and Tier II bonds to fund credit growth.

The bank had done a maiden issuance of infrastructure bonds in December 2024.

Saha said the bank has fully deployed the funds raised from its first infra bonds.

Domestic investors have shown a lot of interest in such bond issuance by banks, and many lenders have exercised this option for raising resources in the recent past.

The advantage of infrastructure bonds is that they are exempt from regulatory reserve requirements such as the Cash Reserve Ratio (CRR) and Statutory Liquidity Ratio (SLR). So, infrastructure bond proceeds can be fully deployed for lending activities. PTI

ADB launches \$70-bn push to connect Asia's power grids, digital networks

ADB announced two major programmes — Pan-Asia Power Grid Initiative & Asia-Pacific Digital Highway — with investments of \$50 billion & \$20 billion

SAMARKAND (Uzbekistan): The Asian Development Bank (ADB) on Sunday said it will back \$70 billion in new energy and digital infrastructure initiatives across Asia and the Pacific by 2035, aimed at strengthening cross-border connectivity and expanding access to electricity and broadband.

Energy and digital access will play a defining role in shaping the region's future, adding that the initiatives seek to link power grids and digital networks to lower costs and expand opportunities, ADB President Masato Kanda said while speaking to the media at the 59th

annual meeting of the bank here.

The bank announced two major programmes — the Pan-Asia Power Grid Initiative and the Asia-Pacific Digital Highway — with proposed investments of \$50 billion and \$20 billion, respectively.

"These two initiatives build the systems Asia and the Pacific need to grow, compete, and connect. By linking power grids and digital networks across borders, we can lower costs, expand opportunity, and bring reliable power and digital access to hundreds of millions of people," he said.

Under the Pan-Asia Power Grid Initiative, ADB will work with governments and private stakeholders to develop cross-border electricity infrastructure, including transmission lines, substations, storage systems and grid modernisation.

The programme aims to integrate around 20 gigawatts of renewable energy, build 22,000 circuit-km of transmission lines, and improve electricity access for 200 million people by 2035.

The initiative is also expected to create about 840,000 jobs and reduce regional power sector emissions by 15 per cent, ADB said, adding that it will finance

CLOSER LOOK

- » 'These two initiatives build the systems Asia and the Pacific need to grow, compete, and connect'
- » ADB expects to contribute \$15 billion to digital initiative and raise the remaining \$5 billion through partnerships
- » Pan-Asia Power Grid Initiative is also expected to create about 840,000 jobs and reduce regional power sector emissions by 15%, the Asian Development Bank said

nearly half of the programme from its own resources while mobilising the rest through co-financing.

ADB said the plan marks a shift towards a more integrated regional approach to

energy trade, building on existing cooperation frameworks such as the ASEAN power grid and the Central Asia Regional Economic Cooperation energy strategy.

The Asia-Pacific Digital

Highway initiative will focus on expanding digital connectivity through investments in fibre networks, satellite links and data centres, alongside policy support and skills development.

The programme aims to provide first-time broadband access to 200 million people and improve connectivity for another 450 million by 2035, while reducing costs in remote areas by around 40 per cent and generating an estimated 4 million jobs.

ADB said it expects to contribute \$15 billion to the digital initiative and raise the remaining \$5 billion through partner-

ships, including with the private sector. As part of the effort, a new centre for AI innovation and development will be set up in Seoul with support from the South Korean government to promote responsible adoption of artificial intelligence and train about 3 million people in digital and AI-related skills.

Expressing his views on the Middle East crisis, Kanda said, "Our region is the one of the most severely impacted by the conflict. The first blow landed in energy, but it did not stop there, with higher prices quickly spilling into fuel, freight, food, and fertiliser.

"What we are seeing is not only a security crisis, but a stress test of the global order. It is a reminder that countries remain highly vulnerable to shocks originating in a few strategic corridors. It is exposing the cost of overreliance, and accelerating the shift from pure efficiency toward resilience," he said.

ADB remains a steadfast partner during these challenging times, he said, adding that the bank announced a financial support package to help developing member countries manage the economic fallout from the Middle East conflict on March 23. PTI

PSBs look to ramp up IT spending in view of cyber threat from Mythos AI

Mythos’ advanced coding capabilities give it unprecedented potential to detect cybersecurity weaknesses & develop methods to exploit them

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Public sector banks are bracing up to increase IT spending in order to secure their systems, safeguard customer data, and protect monetary resources amid global concerns over Anthropic’s Claude Mythos AI tool and its potential implications for financial data security.

Mythos’ advanced coding capabilities give it an unprecedented potential to detect cybersecurity weaknesses and develop methods to exploit them, sparking concerns that it could be used to disrupt banking systems.

In view of this new challenge, banks have to definitely increase their investments in IT to make their system more robust and reduce vulnerabilities with regard to cyber attacks, Punjab & Sind Bank MD and CEO Swarup Kumar Saha said.

He said the bank is going to increase its IT spending this financial year to meet the challenges posed by new technology.

Besides, UCO Bank MD and CEO Ashwani Kumar said the bank’s IT spending is going to be higher than last financial year, and a major part would go towards cyber security.

These statements assume significance in view of Finance



‘In view of this new challenge, banks have to definitely increase their investments in IT to make their system more robust & reduce vulnerabilities with regard to cyber attacks’

Minister Nirmala Sitharaman urging banks to take all necessary pre-emptive measures to secure their IT systems after Mythos exhibited its capability to find weaknesses in their operating system and launch a potential cyber attack.

“Banks in India are now entering a phase where they have to see IT spend from a ‘cost of running’ to a ‘cost of surviving’ spend. Frontier AI systems, especially the unreleased models like Anthropic’s Claude Mythos, do not create a new category of risk; they collapse the

timelines of every existing one,” said Srinivas L, Joint MD & Joint CEO, 63SATS Cybertech Limited, a subsidiary of 63 moons technologies limited.

The window between a public vulnerability of a software/platform disclosure and its weaponisation has compressed from 19 days in 2023 to under 72 hours today. On the other hand, banks are still operating on patching and response cycles designed for a 2019 threat surface, so they are basically defending 2026 attacks with 2019 SOPs, Srinivas said, adding

Highlights

- » Punjab & Sind Bank MD & CEO Swarup Kumar Saha said the bank is going to increase its IT spending this fiscal to meet the challenges posed by the new tech
- » UCO Bank MD & CEO Ashwani Kumar said a major part of bank’s IT spending would go towards cyber security
- » Govt has formed a panel under SBI Chief C S Setty to assess risks emanating from Mythos

that the common instinct has been to add more tools.

To deal with such challenges, the government has formed a panel under SBI Chairman C S Setty to assess risks emanating from the AI platform Mythos and come up with mitigating measures.

There will be a lot of interaction among banks over the next few weeks to understand the threats and also look at the areas where additional investments will be required, Sitharaman said last week.

Mythos has raised alarm

bells among regulators, who see it as a significant challenge to the banking sector and its legacy technology systems. Banks & financial institutions are most vulnerable as there is high interconnected (payments, markets, clearing systems) and dependence on legacy IT systems operating in real-time.

One successful cyberattack can cascade quickly across institutions and markets as one bank is linked to many domestic and global institution for inward and outward payment, forex trading, money market exposure, stock market linkage, depositories and payment gateway, etc.

The pilot launch of Claude Mythos on April 7 raised global concern with regard to their potential hacking capacity. During tests, Anthropic, the US-based artificial intelligence company, found that the latest model was highly skilled at cybersecurity and hacking tasks, outperforming humans.

“Mythos preview has already found thousands of high-severity vulnerabilities, including some in every major operating system and web browser,” Anthropic claimed. Anthropic gave 12 tech companies access via Project Glasswing, which it described as “an effort to secure the world’s most critical software”.

Mcap of four of top-10 cos surges by ₹2.20 lakh crore

Last week, BSE Sensex climbed 249.29 points or 0.32%

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The combined market valuation of four of the top-10 most valued firms surged by Rs 2.20 lakh crore in a holiday-shortened last week, with Reliance Industries emerging as the biggest gainer. Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex climbed 249.29 points or 0.32 per cent.

“Markets ended the week with marginal gains, reflecting a volatile and range-bound trading environment amid mixed global and domestic cues,” Ajit Mishra – SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

The week began on a positive note, supported by easing geopolitical tensions and steady progress in Q4 earnings, which lifted initial sentiment, he said.

However, gains were gradually capped by rising crude oil prices, weak cues from Asian markets, and persistent foreign institutional investor (FII) outflows, Mishra added.

While Reliance Industries, Bharti Airtel, Tata Consultancy Services (TCS) and Bajaj Finance were the gainers from the pack, HDFC Bank, State Bank of India, ICICI Bank, Larsen & Toubro, Hindustan Unilever and Life Insurance Corporation of India (LIC) faced a combined erosion of Rs 1.24 lakh crore from their valuation.

Reliance Industries added Rs 1,39,655.80 crore tak-

Top 10 (BSE)	Market Cap		Gain/Loss over April 24
	₹ crore	As on April 30, 2026	
RIL		19,36,303.30	▲ 1,39,655.80
HDFC Bank		11,87,274.17	▼ -20,951.31
Bharti Airtel		11,49,222.13	▲ 43,503.51
SBI		9,85,829.96	▼ -30,922.57
ICICI Bank		9,04,980.78	▼ -45,364.62
TCS		8,94,933.95	▲ 27,569.83
Bajaj Finance		5,83,123.13	▲ 9,432.32
Larsen & Toubro		5,51,993.05	▼ -178.83
Hind Unilever		5,28,799.01	▼ -18,420.79
LIC		5,04,798.07	▼ -8,222.49

Source: BSE

KBK InfoGraphics

ing its market valuation to Rs 19,36,303.30 crore.

Bharti Airtel’s valuation surged Rs 43,503.51 crore to Rs 11,49,222.13 crore.

The market valuation of TCS jumped Rs 27,569.83 crore to Rs 8,94,933.95 crore and that of Bajaj Finance climbed Rs 9,432.32 crore to Rs 5,83,123.13 crore.

However, the market capitalisation (mcap) of ICICI Bank eroded by Rs 45,364.62 crore to Rs 9,04,980.78 crore.

The valuation of State Bank of India dropped Rs 30,922.57 crore to Rs 9,85,829.96 crore.

The mcap of HDFC Bank

diminished by Rs 20,951.31 crore to Rs 11,87,274.17 crore and that of Hindustan Unilever edged lower by Rs 18,420.79 crore to Rs 5,28,799.01 crore.

The valuation of LIC declined by Rs 8,222.49 crore to Rs 5,04,798.07 crore and that of Larsen & Toubro dipped by Rs 178.83 crore to Rs 5,51,993.05 crore.

Reliance Industries remained the most valued domestic firm followed by HDFC Bank, Bharti Airtel, State Bank of India, ICICI Bank, TCS, Bajaj Finance, Larsen & Toubro, Hindustan Unilever and LIC.

‘Result of state assembly polls, oil prices and quarterly earnings to drive markets this week’

NEW DELHI: Stock markets are likely to be guided this week by the outcome of state elections and high crude oil prices amid the West Asia conflict, say analysts. The developments related to the West Asia conflict and the Strait of Hormuz will also be tracked by investors, they said.

Counting of votes for the five assembly elections in West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Assam, and Puducherry will begin on Monday, May 4.

“The most immediate catalyst will be the outcome of key state elections, with investors closely watching whether the ruling party at the Centre can wrest West Bengal from Trinamool Congress and make meaningful inroads into opposition-ruled Kerala and Tamil Nadu, where the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) currently



has a limited presence,” Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and Founder, Livelong Wealth, said.

Crude oil remains the single most critical macro variable, Hariprasad said.

“With Brent prices sustaining elevated levels amid ongoing tensions around the Strait of Hormuz, inflation risks remain pronounced. For an import-dependent economy like India, persistently high crude prices exert pressure on the rupee—

currently near record lows—and weigh on corporate margins as well as fiscal dynamics,” he added.

Macroeconomic data announcements, Q4 earnings, and foreign investor trading activity would also influence stock market trends this week.

“Crude oil price trends will remain the primary external variable, with the ongoing US–Iran standoff and closure of the Strait of Hormuz likely to keep volatility elevated,” Ajit Mishra, SVP, Research, Religare Broking Ltd, said.

Key macroeconomic data releases include the HSBC Manufacturing PMI (May 4), Services and Composite PMI (May 6), and foreign exchange reserves data (May 8), which will provide insights into economic momentum

and external sector stability, Mishra added.

Major corporate earnings announcements this week are from Ambuja Cements, BHEL, Hero MotoCorp, Mahindra & Mahindra and Bajaj Auto.

“Markets in the week ahead are likely to remain volatile and heavily news-driven. Key attention will remain on the evolving US–Iran dynamic—particularly whether the ceasefire holds, the progress of diplomatic talks, and any developments related to the Strait of Hormuz,” Ponnudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

In a holiday-shortened last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex climbed 249.29 points or 0.32 per cent, and the NSE Nifty went up by 99.6 points or 0.41 per cent.

Maruti Suzuki India starts 2026–27 fiscal with 42% rise in market share

According to industry estimates, the company gained nearly 3 percentage points in market share in April

NEW DELHI: The country’s largest carmaker, Maruti Suzuki India, has started the new fiscal 2026-27 with a 42 per cent market share, increasing from 39 per cent in the previous fiscal.

According to industry estimates, the company, which posted a record domestic sales of 1,91,122 units in April, gained nearly 3 percentage points in market share during the month.

Maruti Suzuki India Senior Executive Officer, Marketing & Sales, Partho Banerjee, said that although the company’s increase in market share has been led by its passenger cars, SUVs have also made a significant contribution.



“We started the new fiscal with a bang in April with record sales and also gained market share,” he said.

The company’s previous highest domestic sales were in December 2025 at 1,82,165 units.

Its passenger car sales were at 96,725 units in April this year

as against 68,244 units in the same month last year.

“In SUV, we have done an all-time high of 55,065 units in April with a growth of 141.6 per cent over last year. We are almost close to the pole position,” Banerjee noted.

As for the sales of small cars comprising models Alto, S-Presso, Celerio and WagonR, he said, “We have grown by 74.4 per cent.”

Carmakers had started the new fiscal on a strong note with an estimated 4.5 lakh units of passenger vehicles sold in April in the domestic market, up 27 per cent as compared to 3.54 lakh units in April last year.

PRSD elects new Governing Board for 2026–28 unopposed on PR Day

NEW DELHI: The Public Relations Society, Delhi (PRSD) on Sunday announced its new Governing Board during National Public Relations Day celebrations at the Press Club of India, with the Executive Committee for 2026–28 elected unopposed. The results were declared by the Returning Officer before industry leaders and professionals.

The Board will be led by Chairman G.S. Bawa, a veteran communication strategist and former General Secretary of PRSD. Dr. Jyoti Kumar, Chief General Manager (Corporate Communications), GAIL (India) Ltd., takes charge as Secretary. The leadership team includes Rama Vijay, former General Manager



(Corporate Communications), REC Ltd., as Vice Chairman; Dr. Akshat Chopra, Deputy Manager (Corporate Communications), Power Grid Corporation of India Ltd., as Joint Secretary; and Vipin Kharbada as Treasurer.

Addressing the gathering, Chairman G.S. Bawa outlined

a focus on professional excellence, enhanced engagement, and enabling young talent through mentoring and skill development. Secretary Dr. Jyoti Kumar emphasised PRSD’s role in upskilling, ethical practices, and fostering thought leadership in a rapidly evolving media landscape.

NEW DELHI: Even as global investors remain wary of oil price volatility and tensions in the Middle East, Morgan Stanley sees the crisis as an opportunity for India, upgrading its outlook on the country’s investment cycle.

The brokerage now expects India’s investment-to-GDP ratio to rise to 37.5 per cent by FY30, up from 36.5 per cent earlier.

This revision implies an additional \$800 billion in cumulative capital expenditure over the next five years, with nearly 60 per cent directed towards energy, data centres and defence.

Higher capital spending is expected to boost corpo-



rate profit share in GDP and support earnings growth of over 15 per cent CAGR during this period. Morgan Stanley believes this momentum could push market valuations towards 10 times FY31 earnings.

The report notes that geopolitical tensions have exposed India’s reliance on imports, particularly in energy and key

inputs, prompting a policy push for self-reliance.

In energy, where India imports 85 per cent of crude oil and 50 per cent of natural gas, strategies include expanding reserves, increasing domestic coal output, scaling renewables and accelerating nuclear capacity.

In fertilisers, efforts focus on boosting domestic urea production and diversifying imports to manage subsidy burdens.

Defence spending is shifting structurally, with allocations projected to rise from around 2 per cent to 2.5 per cent of GDP by FY31, alongside a strong push for indigenisation. Meanwhile, data centre

capacity is expected to surge from 1.8 GW to 10.5 GW by FY31, driven by data localisation and global diversification trends.

Morgan Stanley remains optimistic about India’s medium-term growth, pegging real GDP expansion at 6.5–7 per cent, supported by a virtuous cycle of investment and profitability.

It retains overweight ratings on several companies, including Larsen & Toubro, NTPC, Reliance Industries and Adani Power. Key risks include crude price volatility, fertiliser subsidy pressures, defence execution challenges and power availability for data centres.

‘Gold, silver may remain range-bound next week’

NEW DELHI: Precious metal prices are expected to remain range bound next week as investors track developments in the US-Iran conflict, global economic data releases, and domestic political cues, analysts said.

Traders will closely monitor PMI readings from major economies early in the week, followed by US labour market indicators and non-farm payroll data later in the week for fresh cues on monetary policy and bullion demand, they added.

On MCX, gold futures fell Rs 1,347, or nearly 1 per cent, to close at Rs 1.51 lakh per 10 grams. Silver, however, gained Rs 879 to settle at Rs 2.50 lakh/ kg during the past week.

“Gold traded largely range-bound last week, ending with a negative bias of closing at Rs 1.51 lakh per 10 grams on the MCX,” Jateen Trivedi, VP Research Analyst - Commodity and Currency, LKP Securities, said.

Despite the weak close, the metal showed resilience with a recovery from lower levels, primarily supported by profit booking in crude oil during the latter half of the week, which eased inflationary concerns and lent support to bullion, he added.

In the global markets, Comex gold futures fell \$96.4, or 2.03 per cent to end at \$4,644.5 per ounce over the past week, while silver fell nearly 1 per cent to close at \$75.84 per ounce in New York.

Air India board meet on May 7, cost-saving steps & CEO selection likely on agenda

Headwinds for the Air India Group, which is projected to have incurred more than Rs 22,000 crore loss in FY26, have multiplied with West Asia conflict

NEW DELHI/ MUMBAI: As headwinds persist for the loss-making Air India, its board is expected to discuss cost-saving plans, selection of the next CEO, financials, and other issues during the meeting scheduled for May 7, according to sources.

Headwinds for the Air India Group, which is projected to have incurred more than Rs 22,000 crore loss in the financial year ended March 2026, have multiplied with the West Asia conflict.

In the midst of an ambitious transformation plan, the Tata Group-owned airline is also scouting for a new CEO as

incumbent and Singapore Airlines Group veteran Campbell Wilson will be stepping down later this year. The sources said the board, chaired by Tata Sons Chairman N Chandrasekaran, will meet in Mumbai on May 7.

Various cost-saving measures, CEO succession plans, financials for 2025-26 fiscal year as well as other issues are expected to be discussed during the meeting, the sources said.

As part of stringent measures to save costs amid spiralling jet fuel prices, Air India is mulling unbundling meals from tickets as well as lounge access for business class travellers.



With the unbundling plan, the airline will be able to offer a different fare category where passengers do not prefer to have meals. Similarly, the business class passengers will have the option to choose lounge access, the sources said.

CLOSER LOOK

- » As part of costs saving measures, Air India is mulling unbundling meals from tickets & biz class lounge access
- » With the plan, airline will be able to offer different fare category where passengers do not prefer to have meals
- » Similarly, the business class passengers will have the option to choose lounge access, the sources said

They also stressed that these measures are only being mulled and a final decision has not been taken on whether to go ahead with it.

Airspace restrictions in the wake of the West Asia conflict have forced the airline to take

longer routes for many international destinations, which is also resulting in increased fuel burn.

The board is also expected to discuss the selection of the next CEO for the airline, in which Singapore Airlines has a 25.1 per cent stake. Various names,

including that of Air India and Singapore Airlines executives as well as possible European candidates, are doing the rounds for the next CEO position.

One of the sources indicated that there could even be the possibility of having a joint MD or CEO.

Apart from Chandrasekaran and Wilson, Singapore Airlines CEO Goh Choon Phong and four others — Sanjiv Mehta, Alice Vaidyan, P R Ramesh, and P B Balaji — are members of the Air India board. On May 1, Wilson told staff that the airspace and jet fuel price situation remains extremely challenging.

“... massive rise in jet fuel prices which, together with airspace closures and longer flying routes, has caused many of our international flights to become unprofitable to operate,” he had said in a message.

While cuts in international flights happened in April and is continuing in May, Wilson had also said the situation leaves the airline with no choice “but to further trim schedules for June and July”.

“We very much regret the disruption to our customers’ plans and our crew’s rosters, and hope that the Middle East situation settles -- and the Strait of

Hormuz opens -- soon so that we can get back to a more normal state,” he had said.

According to him, the profitability of domestic flights has also been significantly affected, but to a lower degree due to the government’s limitation of the domestic fuel price rise to 25 per cent.

“To partially compensate for the huge spike in costs, we have increased airfares and imposed fuel surcharges but, understandably, these higher airfares impact customer demand, so we can only raise fares so far before people decide to stay home,” he had said.

THIS WAS THE FIRST TIME SRH WERE BOWLED OUT IN THE IPL 2026

Chakravarth, Narine shine as KKR snap SRH's 5-match winning streak

HYDERABAD: A resurgent Varun Chakravarth and milestone man Sunil Narine were instrumental in Kolkata Knight Riders' comprehensive seven-wicket victory that snapped Sunriser Hyderabad's five-match winning streak in the Indian Premier League, here on Sunday.

After Chakravarth (3/36) and Narine (2/31) played major roles in bowling out SRH for 165 in 19 overs, KKR chased down the target with 10 balls to spare to notch their third win on the trot.

This was leg-spinner Chakravarth's fourth successive match in which he took at least two wickets while veteran off-spinner Narine joined an exclusive three-member 200-wicket club in the IPL.

Playing his 197th match, Narine, who also opened KKR's bowling, joined pacer Bhuvneshwar Kumar (215 from 199 matches) and spinner Yuzvendra Chahal (228 from 182 matches) in the elite group.

Chasing a small target, KKR lost Impact Sub Finn Allen in the fourth over for a quick-fire 39 off 13 balls when the team score was 49 but captain Ajinkya Rahane (43 off 36



Kolkata Knight Riders' Angkrish Raghuvanshi celebrates his fifty runs during the Indian Premier League match against Sunrisers Hyderabad on Sunday

balls) and Angkrish Raghuvanshi (59 off 47 balls) held the innings together with a second wicket stand of 84 runs from 11 overs.

Rahane, who scored just one half century in previous eighth matches at the top of the order, hit four boundaries and a six, while Raghuvanshi struck

five boundaries and two sixes.

Rinku Singh struck the winning runs -- a four -- as he remained not out on 22 off 11 balls.

Earlier, opting to bat, SRH were in their usual menacing batting form, reaching 77 for 1 after powerplay and 107 for 2 at the halfway mark, courtesy Tra-

vis Head's (61 off 28 balls) second consecutive half century.

But they collapsed spectacularly in the second half of their innings, losing nine wickets in 10 overs for the addition of 60 runs.

This was the first time SRH were bowled out in the IPL 2026.

44

The explosive Australian batter stitched 44 runs in just 3.4 overs with Abhishek Sharma (15 off 10 balls) for the opening wicket

Kartik Tyagi chipped in with 2/30.

Head's innings was laced with nine fours and three sixes, and he was well supported by Ishan Kishan (42 off 29 balls). This was the third successive match SRH had scored more than 100 runs inside first 10 overs.

The explosive Australian batter stitched 44 runs in just 3.4 overs with Abhishek Sharma (15 off 10 balls) for the opening wicket and then had an alliance of 61 runs with Kishan for the second wicket.

Barcelona win at Osasuna, on the cusp of La Liga title

Barcelona opened a 14-point gap over Real Madrid with four rounds left after this weekend

BARCELONA: Robert Lewandowski and Ferran Torres scored late in Barcelona's 2-1 win at Osasuna on Saturday that set up a chance for Hansi Flick's side to be crowned Spanish league champions this weekend.

Barcelona opened a 14-point gap over Real Madrid with four rounds left after this weekend. Madrid must win at Espanyol on Sunday to stop Barcelona from clinching a second straight La Liga crown.

A victory by Madrid would prolong the title fight another week, when Barcelona hosts Madrid in a "clasico" match.

Substitute Marcus Rashford picked out a run by Lewandowski and placed a cross for the striker to thump in with a powerful header in the 81st minute. That sparked a flurry of goals in the final minutes. Torres added a second goal five minutes later, and Raúl García headed in one for Osasuna in the 89th. Atletico wins before Arsenal clash:

Atletico Madrid rested most of its starters but got goals from two debutants as it won 2-0 at Valencia before it faces Arsenal for a place in the Champions League final.

Julián Álvarez, Alexander



Barcelona's Robert Lewandowski celebrates after scoring his side's opening goal during a Spanish La Liga football match in Pamplona

“

SUBSTITUTE MARCUS RASHFORD PICKED OUT A RUN BY LEWANDOWSKI AND PLACED A CROSS FOR THE STRIKER

”

Sorloth and Giuliano Simeone, who all finished Wednesday's 1-1 draw with Arsenal with niggles, were among those players left off Atletico's squad for the Spanish league game.

Atletico travels to London for the second leg of their Champions League semifinal on Tuesday.

Diego Simeone called up nine youth team players for the visit to Valencia, with Iker Luque and Miguel Cubo coming on in the second half and scoring in the 73rd and 82nd for the win at Mestalla Stadium.

Atletico defender Nahuel Molina almost scored one of the goals of the season when he let rip a powerful strike from near the midfield circle that smacked the corner of the goal frame in the first half.

Atletico remained in fourth place and on course for another Champions League berth next season. Valencia was 13th and still in danger of falling into a relegation battle.

Sinner crushes Zverev to win Madrid Open

MADRID: Top-ranked Jan-nik Sinner cruised past Alexander Zverev in the final of the Madrid Open to win the tournament for the first

Sinner beat the third-ranked Zverev 6-1, 6-2 on Sunday for his 23rd straight win

time and become the first man to win five consecutive Masters 1000 events.

Sinner beat the third-ranked Zverev 6-1, 6-2 on Sunday for his 23rd straight win. He had already won Master 1000 tournaments in Monte Carlo, Miami and Indian Wells this year, and in Paris last year.

Zverev lost to Sinner in the semifinals of each of those tournaments.

He won in Madrid in 2018 and 2021, and was runner-up to Carlos Alcaraz in 2022.

In the women's final on Saturday, Marta Kostyuk of Ukraine beat Mirra Andreeva of Russia 7-5, 6-3.

Ojeda gets hat trick, Messi and Inter Miami waste 3-0 lead and fall 4-3 to Orlando City

Messi had a goal and two assists in his 100th appearance for the club

MIAMI: Lionel Messi and Inter Miami had a 3-0 lead, against in-state rival Orlando City, on co-owner David Beckham's 51st birthday no less, finally looking poised to get the long-awaited first win on its new home field.

Martin Ojeda and Orlando City had other ideas.

Ojeda scored three goals, Tyrese Spicer had the go-ahead goal in the third minute of stoppage time and Orlando City stunned Inter Miami 4-3 on Saturday night — ending the reigning MLS champions' 11-game unbeaten streak across all competitions.

Messi had a goal and two assists in his 100th appearance for the club, and somehow, that wasn't enough against a team that came into the night near the bottom of the MLS standings. Inter Miami fell to 0-1-3 at its new stadium.

Ian Fray and Telasco Segovia also scored for Inter Miami, which was unbeaten (5-0-6) in its last 11 matches across all competitions and its last nine matches (5-0-4) in MLS play.



Inter Miami forward Lionel Messi (10) battles for the ball with Orlando City defender Robin Jansson (6) in the second half during an MLS football match

Orlando City (3-7-1) had won only two of its last 15 MLS matches — including play-offs — dating to last season. Orlando City also was 0-4-1 on the road in MLS play this

season. None of that mattered. Ojeda scored in the 39th minute to send Orlando into the half down 3-1. He scored again in the 68th minute to make matters interesting. Too inter-

esting from the Inter Miami perspective. Ojeda had a great chance to tie it in the 73rd minute, alone on the right side of the box. But Inter Miami goalkeeper Dayne St. Clair came

Sudharsan's fifty, pacers' brilliance lift GT to 4-wicket win over PBKS

AHMEDABAD: Sai Sudharsan's cool-headed 57 alongside the storm kicked up by pacers Mohammed Siraj, Jason Holder and Kagiso Rabada carried Gujarat Titans to a last over four-wicket victory over Punjab Kings in their IPL match here on Sunday.

On a slightly slow pitch, the Titans needed a level-headed chase of 164, and Sudharsan did precisely during his 41-ball knock.

A similar innings from debutant Suryansh Shedge's energetic 57 had helped PBKS to post 163 for nine despite Siraj (2/28) and Holder (4/24) reducing them to 47 for five in 8.4 overs.

But it was Sudharsan's turn to stand on the winners' podium in the battle of half-centurions on the night. The result meant that GT stayed at five in the table but their points tally swelled to 12, while PBKS also maintained their top spot with 13 points for now.

After skipper Shubman Gill fell early to Arshdeep Singh, Sudharsan took control of the chase and added 53 runs for the second wicket with Jos Buttler.

Buttler (25) was the more dominant partner, dismissing Marco Jansen and Xavier Bartlett for a six each, the second one being an audacious scoop over the wicketkeeper.

But the England batter could not clear the infield off Vyshak Vijayakumar, giving a



Gujarat Titans' Sai Sudharsan in action

After skipper Shubman Gill fell early to Arshdeep Singh, Sudharsan took control of the chase and added 53 runs for the second wicket with Jos Buttler

catch to Shreyas Iyer.

But Sudharsan continued undeterred and reached his third fifty of this IPL season off 37 balls.

The left-hander celebrated that with a couple of fours off Yuzvendra Chahal but could not impart distance to a pull off Vysakh, getting caught on

the ropes by Bartlett.

The dismissal of Rahul Tewatia added some more drama to the close contest, with GT needing 11 runs off the final over.

But Washington Sundar (40 not out, 23b) stayed long enough to finish the match with a scooped six off Marcus Stoinis.

Earlier, Shedge made a well-made fifty but GT could not progress beyond 163 for nine.

But even that total looked distant once the Gujarat pacers found their wares early in the innings.

However, Shedge's 29 ball innings, instrumental in a 79-run alliance for the sixth wicket with Stoinis (40) helped Punjab to recover from that precarious place to some extent.

Man United beat Liverpool 3-2 in Champions League

MANCHESTER: Manchester United guaranteed a return to the Champions League next season with a 3-2 win against Liverpool on Sunday.

Kobbie Mainoo settled a thrilling Premier League clash at Old Trafford with his first-time strike from the edge of the area.

Defending champion Liverpool had fought back from two goals down to level the game. But Mainoo's goal meant United would again be playing in European club soccer's top competition after a two-year absence.

To the delight of its fans, United also completed a league double of home-and-away wins against Liverpool

for the first time since the 2015-16 campaign.

Victory saw Michael Carrick achieve the target he was set when in January he was handed the role of head coach until the end of the season. Rescuing United's season from freefall, he has led the club to third in the standings and produced statement wins against Arsenal, Manchester City and now Liverpool.

Victory will strengthen calls for Carrick to be handed the job on a permanent basis.

Matheus Cunha put United ahead after six minutes with a left-footed strike from inside the box and Benjamin Sesko doubled the lead in the 14th when bundling in from close range.

New Okhla Industrial Development Authority
Administrative Building, Sector-6, Noida, (UP)
Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in

E-TENDER NOTICE
E-Tenders are invited from eligible contractors/firm for the following jobs against which bids can be uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders are available on Noida Authority's official website: www.noidaauthorityonline.in & <https://etender.up.nic.in>. Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/amendments & corrigendum etc.

A) Fresh-Tender Work:

S. No.	Job No.	Name of the work	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs)
1.	02/GM/SM(WC-2)/ET/2026-27	M/o Road (P/F Retro Reflective overhead signage Board in Village Nithari & Ambedkar Vihar in different location), Noida.	22.17
2.	25/GM/SM(WC-5)/2026-27	D/o Village (C / o Toilet in Park near Composite School at Village-Gijhore and P/F and repair of M.S. Jaal in Village-Gijhore), Noida.	26.48
3.	06/GM/SM(WC-1)/2026-27	P/L Thermoplastic Paint on Udyog Marg Sector-14A Flyover to Sector-11, T-Point, Noida.	29.50
4.	40/DGM/SM(WC-5)/2025-26	M/o Building (Repair and Raising of Boundary wall of Community Centre in Sector-34), Noida.	9.77
5.	26/GM/SM(WC-5)/2026-27	M/o Building (R/o OHT Type-1 Staff Quarter balance work in Sector-24), Noida.	22.19

The above tenders can be uploaded from **dated 04.05.2026 to 18.05.2026 up to 5.00 PM**. Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on dated **19.05.2026 at 11.00 AM**.

B) Re-Tender Work:

S. No.	Job No.	Name of the work	Tender Amount (Rs. Lacs)
6.	31/SM(WC-4)/ET/2025-26	D/o & M/o Village (R/o damaged Approach road of Chhajarsi Shamshan Ghat), Noida.	22.57
7.	13/GM/SM(WC-1)/2025-26	Direction Boards at different Sector (Supply and fixing of Retro Reflective Direction Boards at Sector-4, 9, 10, 14A, 15A and 55), Noida.	26.70
8.	65/DGM/SM(WC-5) / 2025-2026	M/o Road (P/F Retro Reflective Signage Board in Sector-61), Noida.	23.12
9.	47/DGM/SM(WC-3)/2026-27	D/o Village (R/o drain and fixing M.S. Jaal in Village Hoshiyarpur, Sector-51), Noida.	27.77
10.	55/DGM/SM(WC-3)/2026-27	M/o Building (C/o Toilet nearby V.D.S. Market Sector-51) Noida	10.37
11.	07/GM/SM(E&M-III)/ 2025-26	Annual Operation and routine Maintenance of Electrical Equipment such as L.T. Pannel, CCTV Camera, ISTMS Equipment at Command Control Centre Sector-94, Noida.	14.28

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General Manager (Civil)

CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

AYUSHMANN KHURRANA ON 'PATI PATNI AUR WOHO DO'

'NOT PROMOTING INFIDELITY'

He described the film as a 'wholesome family entertainer'



MUMBAI: Ayushmann Khurrana said his upcoming film 'Pati Patni Aur Woh Do' doesn't endorse infidelity, describing it as a 'wholesome family entertainer'. The film is directed by Mudassar Aziz and blends situational comedy with everyday relationship dynamics, confusion and unexpected turns.

"The way Mudassar has woven this classic iconic story is brilliant. It's not a romcom; there's more comedy in the film. My role as Prajapati Pandey is a green flag, whose moral compass is correct. We are not promoting infidelity because it's a family film. Everyone will enjoy watching this film; it's a comedy of errors," Khurrana told reporters at the trailer launch.

The actor said he is cognisant of his 'responsibility' and added that he chooses stories that the family audience can watch. "Being a family man, I think I should do films that my kids can watch. I had taken my kids when we were editing this film and they loved it. When kids love it, then it becomes a wholesome family film and 'Pati Patni Aur Woh Do' is one such film. I think people want to watch a nice, fun comedy film and it is that film."

The actor said he chooses stories that the family audience can watch

MIXED SIGNALS: A Dramedy of Errors

Aadyam Theatre has announced its second production, 'Dil Ka Hal Sune Dilwala'

JAI TALWAR

Aadyam Theatre has announced its second production 'Dil Ka Hal Sune Dilwala', a dramedy on identity and connection, for an India-wide release premiering at Kamani Auditorium, Delhi, with three shows in mid-May and two in Mumbai at the end of May.

Directed by Mohit Takalkar, the play is based on Sarah Ruhl's 'Dead Man's Cellphone' and reimagines the story within the pulse and texture of Mumbai. It is expected to be a tender, playful adaptation infused with music, humour and theatrical flair.

The play revolves around Parekh, a struggling actress from Surat, who spends her days waiting tables, when one afternoon, she answers the ring-



ing phone of a man who has just died. What begins as an innocent act soon draws her into the many lives

It is expected to be a tender, playful adaptation infused with music, humour and theatrical flair

he leaves behind, a world of fragile truths and shifting identities. With a narrator and live music shaping her journey, the play unfolds through fragments, rhythm and memory.

Takalkar is a widely regarded theatre director with a body of work spanning over two decades. Since his early production of Girish Karnad's 'Yayati' in 1999, he has directed more than 35 plays across Marathi, English, Urdu, Kannada and Marwari. Talking about the play, Mohit

Takalkar said, "When I came across Sarah Ruhl's 'Dead Man's Cellphone', I was immediately drawn to its absurdity that also carries a hint of tenderness. So, 'Dil Ka Hal Sune Dilwala' felt like a gift. While it is funny and chaotic on the surface, it quietly explores how we search for connection, forgiveness and belonging - sometimes in the most unexpected ways."

The production features a dynamic ensemble, led by Dilnaz Irani as Asha Parekh, along with Vrajesh Hirjee, Faezah Jalali, Sagar Deshmukh and Bhaskar Sharma. With this production, Aadyam Theatre continues its exploration of bold, contemporary storytelling and this time through a form that is as entertaining as it is tender and thought-provoking.

Karan to make Met Gala debut



LOS ANGELES: Filmmaker Karan Johar is set to make his Met Gala debut and will wear a custom outfit from the celebrity designer Manish Malhotra.

Malhotra confirmed the news to CBS's 'Saturday Morning', adding there will be 'a lot more on the red carpet'. "This time, I'm gonna be designing for a very big director who's known for his fashion and movies, Karan Johar... There's gonna be a lot more coming up on the red carpet... Let's wait and watch," he said.

The filmmaker has worn several of the designer's outfits over the years.

Last year, Bollywood star Shah Rukh Khan made his debut at the event. He wore an attire by Sabyasachi, which comprised an all-black bespoke outfit, complete with crystal chains and a dandy cane.

The Met Gala is an annual high-profile fundraising event for the Metropolitan Museum of Art's Costume Institute in New York City. This year, it will take place on May 4. The theme for this year is 'Costume Art'. Several celebrities are expected to attend the event, including Rihanna and Zendaya, among others.

'Balan: The Boy' to have market screening at Cannes

The film will be screened on May 14

NEW DELHI: 'KVN Productions' and 'Thespian Films' film 'Balan: The Boy', directed by Chidambaram, is set to have a market screening in the 'Marche du Film' segment at the Cannes Film Festival.

The event is set to take place between May 12 and May 23. The film will be screened on May 14, according to a press release. 'Balan: The Boy' is written by Jithu Madhavan and revolves around a journey that explores themes of identity, survival and the enduring bond between a mother and her child.

"Balan The Boy' is a film about what we carry without knowing... The weight of where we come from and the hunger to find where we belong. I made this film for the person who has felt both of those things deeply and never found the words for them. Cannes has always been a home for cinema that trusts its



It revolves around a journey that explores themes of identity, survival and the enduring bond between a mother and her child

audience with exactly that kind of truth and 'Balan: The Boy' trusts its audience completely. To feel before they understand. And to carry something home long after it is over," Chidambaram said.

Venkat K Narayana of 'KVN Productions' added, "'Balan: The Boy' is not just a film; it is a statement. The kind that reminds you exactly why you

got into this industry in the first place. Malayalam cinema is making work the world cannot afford to ignore and we are at Cannes because we believe, with everything we have, that 'Balan: The Boy' belongs at the centre of that conversation."

Shailaja Desai Fenn of 'Thespian Films' said it's a 'matter of immense pride' to have the film screened at Cannes.

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